



ANNUAL 5 REPORT

June 2022-August 2023



This WBF Annual Report has been produced with the financial support of the International Visegrad Fund.

IVF is a key strategic partner for the Western Balkans Fund and we sincerely appreciate their support.

- supported by
- Visegrad Fund
-
-

Table of Content

05 Welcoming Message

EFFICENCY

06 Guiding Principles

61 Delivering on key priorities

REGIONAL COOPERATION

63 Organisational Development

08 Regional Ownership

65 Enhancing the visibility of our mission

12 Partners and peers

71 Internship Program

20 Regional Networking

EFFECTIVENESS

PEOPLE TO PEOPLE LINKS

74 Delivering on strategic goals

27 WBF-EU Joint Action

77 Monitoring & Mentoring

55 Move Grants

TRANSPARENCY

59 Beyond Grant Schemes

79 Financial Report

82 Innovation & Digitalisation

84 The way forward



About the Report

Annual Report No. 5 encompasses the timeframe spanning from June 2022 to August 2023. This is the fifth Annual Report published by the Western Balkans Fund, but the first that is named by numbers, with the previous ones named by years.

This change has been implemented due to the fact that our reporting periods do not align with the standard calendar year. Beginning from this year onwards, all subsequent Annual Reports will be numbered.

The fifth Annual Report offers comprehensive insights into our networking endeavors, partnerships, influential advocacy events, and a focal point: the implementation or awarding of over 100 regional projects.

It extensively focuses into the workings of both the 4th and 5th Calls for Proposals, which were co-funded by the European Union. Furthermore, it provides an in-depth examination of the 1st and 2nd Calls for Proposals of the WBF Move Grants – an innovative grant mechanism initiated in March 2023.

The report also sheds light on various other projects that have received our support. It highlights the diverse range of initiatives, including those focused on youth empowerment, educational exchange, cultural heritage preservation, environmental sustainability, and economic cooperation.

It also features an extensive coverage of a growing organism, that of the Fund, that in his sixth year of existence continues to become a greater and stronger organisation supporting Cooperation and Reconciliation all over the Western Balkans Region.

Welcoming Message

Dear Partners, friends and beneficiaries of the Western Balkans Fund (WBF)

We are happy to share with you this Annual Report, which coincides with a period of unprecedented growth and unforeseen institutional strengthening of our Fund.

The period from June 2022 to August 2023 is a period in which the Fund has become a much more influential and active mechanism all over the Western Balkans.

A busy networking agenda, dozens of regional visits, our growing advocacy events and tools, as of the more than 100 projects implemented or awarded during this period are the witnesses of this growth.

Thanks to the wisdom and unconditional support of our Contracting Parties and our distinguished partners, WBF has expanded the portfolio of intervention and grants, thus being able to shape the present and the future of our Region at an unprecedented rate.

Heartfelt thanks to the dedicated members of the WBF family and all of our growing list of stakeholders and beneficiaries, for following, trusting and supporting us.



A busy networking agenda, dozens of regional visits, our growing advocacy events and tools, as of the more than 100 projects implemented or awarded during this period are the witnesses of this growth.

WBF Guiding Principles

The Western Balkans Fund is guided on five big principles, part of Strategic Development Plan of 2020-24

Principle 1: Regional Cooperation, Ownership, Inclusiveness

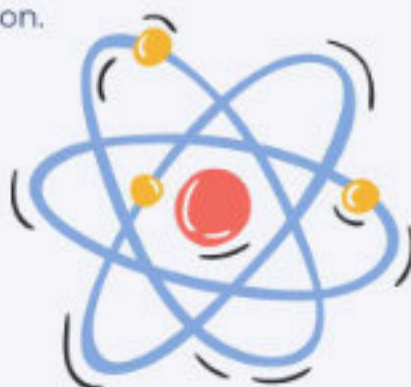
WBF exists because of the people of the Region. Its mission is to provide investment in regional cooperation in such a way that they translate to tangible benefits for the people of the Region.

Principle 2: People to People Links

WBF is available to all civil society and individuals' initiatives of the Region, regardless of their religious and/or any other beliefs, the language they use or any other personal characteristics.

Principle 5: Transparency

Information about activities and overall management has always been publicly available because the WBF believes that openness and accountability is very important.



Principle 3: Efficiency

The WBF strives to achieve the best possible results with the minimum resources. The principle of efficiency is therefore applied both in the implementation of projects and administration.

Principle 4: Effectiveness

The WBF attaches great importance to achieving a clear and concrete results and has developed mechanisms to monitor its work and the results of its projects. As such, this strategic plan represents the basis of cooperation between the Western Balkans Fund and civil society around the Western Balkans Region, by committing the financial support of six governments in creating favourable conditions for strengthening regional cooperation.



September 2017, Bled, creation of the WBF

CHAPTER I - Regional Cooperation

- Regional Ownership
- Our Partners
- Networking & Advocacy

Principle 1

WBF exists because of the people of the Region. Its mission is to provide investment in regional cooperation in such a way that they translate to tangible benefits for the people of the Region.



Contracting Parties



International Partners



Networking Events and Initiatives



Regional Ownership

Established by the Ministries of Foreign Affairs of six Contracting Parties, the Fund is fully regionally owned.

It is one of the few regional Initiatives to have MFAs as the main governing body. This allows a level of access to policymakers that few peers can match.

The Fund's Council of Senior Officials are dynamically engaged in guiding and leveraging the Fund as a leading regional investor in achieving the Fund's Mission.

The fact that Contracting Parties have already tripled their funding since start-up is a compelling demonstration of trust in the Fund's impact and potential.

WBF is the first Regional Initiative in the WB, having all WB6 Contracting Parties as co-founders and recognising each other as equal partners in an international organisation.

The uniqueness of the Fund is that funds it provides for civil society and other initiatives originate not just from the individual Ministries of Foreign Affairs of the Contracting Party territory where grantees live but also from funds pooled in a relationship of trust and mutual commitment by all six Contracting Parties. This is reconciliation and trust-building in action.



H.E. Olta Xhaçka, Minister of Foreign Affairs and Europe of Albania, attending to the WBF-EU Joint Action kick-off

Council of Senior Officials Meetings

According to the WBF Statute, the Council of Senior Officials (CSO) is formed by the Ministries of Foreign Affairs of the Contracting Parties. They act as a supervisory and decision-making body to whom the WBF relies for guidance, legitimacy and approval.

Since the last Annual Report published on September 2022, the Council of Senior Officials have had three meetings. In September 2022, the CSO Meeting, led by the Belgrade 2022 Chairmanship-in-Office, opened the way to launching a new grant-giving mechanism, the Move Grants.

January meeting was crucial for setting up the 2023 workplan, while May CSO meeting contributed to further strengthening of Fund's.

Belgrade 2022 Chairmanship in Office

Belgrade chairmanship of the Fund continued the work of the Skopje chairmanship, but also focused on four key objectives of common interest:

Continued institutional strengthening of the WBF and staff professionalisation.

Increasing regional and international visibility of the Western Balkans Fund.

Deepening of cooperation with partners from the European Union, Switzerland, Japan and other perspective donors, as well encouraging the increase of contributions by the six Contracting Parties.

And the continuation of cooperation with the International Visegrad Fund and the V4.



Pavle Jankovic, member of the Council of Senior Officials, representing Belgrade at a WBF reception, October 2022



The Fund has demonstrated and proven itself as a unique cooperation mechanism and a good example of other initiatives of how to put the need before differences in the pursuit of a common, overarching goal

H.E. Ivica Dacic, Minister of Foreign Affairs of Serbia

One of the most notable achievements of the Belgrade presidency was the successful increase of the core budget, thanks an agreement reached by all the Contracting Parties.

As of 2023, the share provided by the

MFA has triplicated compared with the initial established running budget in 2017.

Thanks to the wise-leadership, the Fund also greatly enhanced regional and international partnerships and reputation.

Tirana 2023 Chairmanship in Office

Following the established practice of a rotating Chairmanship-in-Office that each year passed to another Contracting Party based on a pre-established calendar, the CiO of the Fund rotated to Tirana in 2023.

The formal takeover from Belgrade 2022 Chairmanship-in-Office was announced on 6 January 2023 by the Minister of Foreign Affairs and Europe of the Republic of Albania, HE Olta Xhaçka.

The Tirana 2023 CiO has identified three main priorities that will be followed during the year.

1.Further institutional strengthening of the Western Balkans Fund

2.Increasing Fund visibility throughout the Region and beyond



Ilir Melo (L), member of the Council of Senior Officials, representing Tirana presents a Grant Award Certificate

3.Continuation and strengthening of the cooperation with the existing partners and creation of new partnerships



We will continue to reinforce our proactive role in the Region throughout 2023 with hosting the 2023 Berlin Process Summit and the Chairmanship-in-Office of the Western Balkans Fund

H.E. Olta Xhaçka, Minister of Foreign Affairs and Europe, Republic of Albania

DO YOU KNOW?

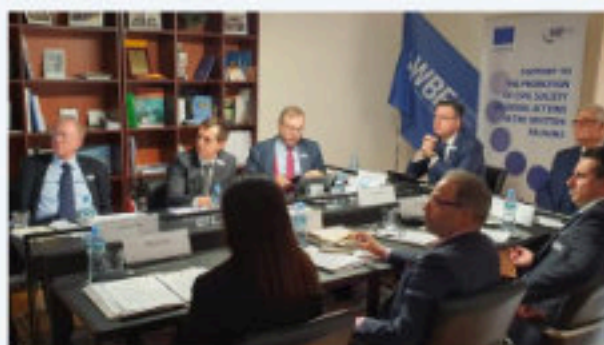
Each year, the Chairmanship-in-Office of the Western Balkans Fund passes to a new Contracting Party on a rotating format. Each Contracting Party is able to propose and pursue a list of objectives during their Chairmanship. As of 2023, the Chairmanship of the Fund has passed to all of our Contracting Parties as follows:

- Tirana 2017 Chairmanship-in-Office
- Sarajevo 2018 Chairmanship-in-Office
- Prishtina 2019 Chairmanship-in-Office
- Podgorica 2020 Chairmanship-in-Office
- Skopje 2021 Chairmanship-in-Office
- Belgrade 2022 Chairmanship-in-Office
- Tirana 2023 Chairmanship-in-Office
- Sarajevo 2024 Chairmanship-in-Office

The Council of Senior Officials

The Council of Senior Officials consists of Senior Officials from the Ministries of Foreign Affairs of the Contracting Parties or other duly appointed representatives and meets at least once every six months. In average, the CSO meets at the premises of our Secretariat 3-4 times a year. The Council of Senior Officials prepares draft budgets of the Fund, reports on their utilization in the preceding year and submits them for approval to the Conference of Ministers of Foreign Affairs.

The Council of Senior Officials also lays down binding guidelines for the activities of the Executive Director and rules governing the preparation, acceptance and implementation of projects submitted to the Fund, taking into account the rules regulating the rights and duties of the Executive Director set forth by the Conference of Ministers of Foreign Affairs. Since the last publication, the CSO has met three times.



CSO Meeting of 29-30 September 2022

The September meeting, above other took the decision for the endorsement of amendment of WBFF budget and the Human Resources Manual. It will remain forever as a key milestone in WBFF history, because of the decision taken by the Contracting Parties to increase the Annual Contributions from 60.000 to 90.000 Euros.



CSO Meeting of 24 January 2023

At this meeting took place the transfer of the Chairmanship-in-Office from Belgrade to Tirana. At the meeting it was decided the approval of WBFF budget and action plan of 2023.



CSO Meeting of 17-18 May 2023

The meeting approved the shortlisted projects of the First Call for Proposals of the WBFF Move Grants

Pictures corresponding to the **cronologic order** of the text

Teaming up for a better Region

We are extremely proud of the growing partnerships with like-minded partners. In almost six years since our establishment, many have joined, but none has left. It is an amazing feature that demonstrates the important and positive impact of the Fund in shaping the present and future of the Western Balkans Region



EUROPEAN UNION



Based on the commitments deriving from the Sofia 2018 Declaration and the 2019 Poznan Summit, the Fund strengthened the cooperation with European Union Commission with the purpose of supporting and promoting projects and initiatives that enhance regional cooperation, contribute to the sustainable development of the Western Balkans, and strengthen the bonds between the people of the region.

As a result, In 12 July 2021, the Fund concluded the cooperation agreement with EU Commission by signing the contract for the WBF/EU Joint Action to foster regional cooperation and contribute to the development of the Western Balkans.

Based on this agreement, the European Union became co-funder of the 4th and the 5th Call for Proposals.

The deriving Joint-Action has supported up to 15.000 Euros 69 regional projects, with thousands of direct beneficiaries.

Thanks to the EU impact, cross-cutting issues such as human rights, gender equality, sustainable growth and green economy have been attracting more and more support from the WBF.

Key dates of WBF-EU cooperation

May 2018 - Sofia EU-WB Declaration

July 2019 - WB Poznan Summit

July 2021 - WBF-EU agreement signed

November 2021 - Official launch of the WBF-EU Joint Action and launching of the First Join Call for Proposals

April 2022 - Awarding Ceremony, 1 CFP of the Joint Action

May 2022 - Launch of the 2 CFP for Proposals

19 December 2022 - Awarding Ceremony, 2 CFP of the Join Action



EU and Swiss Ambassadors to Tirana, H.E. Hohmann and H.E. Ruth, together at the WBF organised Unstoppable Conference

SWITZERLAND



Switzerland and the Swiss Development and Cooperation Agency are key partners for the Western Balkans Fund.

The Swiss Government currently supports the institutional strengthening and the strategic development of the Fund in the period 2021-25. Part of this support is also the WBF Move Grants.

These grants are a new WBF Regional Grant Mechanism, tailor-made to support the needs of Civil Society Organisations and individuals in the Western Balkans Area.

MOVE Grants are a diversified and second grant giving mechanism, that add up to the Call for Proposals (otherwise know as the WBF-EU Joint Action). The MOVE scheme is being supported financially by the Fund core budget using funds prevenient by the SDC core contribution.



MINISTRY OF FOREIGN AFFAIRS OF JAPAN (MOFA)



The Western Balkans Fund and the MOFA Japan have initiated a collaborative partnership rooted in the Western Balkans Cooperation Initiative, which was pioneered by former Prime Minister, H.E. ABE Shinzo.

The relationship between WBF and MOFA Japan began with initial contacts established through the Embassy of Japan in Tirana.

Recognizing WBF as a trusted partner with a strong presence and extensive outreach in the Western Balkans region, as well as a wide network of stakeholders, MOFA Japan identified the potential for fruitful collaboration and engagement.

Starting from 2020, MOFA Japan extended financial support to WBF by assisting in the organization of the "Civil Society Summit."

In response to the COVID-19 pandemic, WBF, with the support of MOFA Japan, implemented a project titled "Impact of COVID-19 on Western Balkan Region Civil Society Organizations."

This second event provided support and a roadmap to full recovery to Civil Society Organisations.

In 2022, the cooperation focused on the organisation of the international Conference "Promote Culture of Tolerance and Mutual Respect between two Regions (FIRE Conference)".

In 2023, together we organised the largest joint event to date, "Unstoppable" Conference, focused on women and leadership (more on the Conference page 18).

The Conference brought to Tirana 150 distinguished participants from more than 20 countries. Both FIRE and Unstoppable Conference benefited also from the generous support of the International Visegrad Fund.



International Visegrad Fund

WBF was largely created based on the model of the very successful International Visegrad Fund (IVF).

As such, IVF has been our very first partner and the one who, by providing technical assistance and guidance,

IVF continues to actively promote WBF and its outreach efforts through various channels.

This includes organising information sessions and disseminating newsletters that highlight the work and achievements of WBF.

Moreover, IVF has contributed to raising awareness about WBF and its mission, fostering a broader understanding and engagement within the region.

The collaboration between WBF and IVF serves as a prime example of regional cooperation and mutual support.

It showcases the significance of partnerships in driving shared objectives and advancing peacebuilding initiatives.

It exemplifies how regional organizations can leverage their strengths and resources to create a positive and lasting impact on peacebuilding, regional integration, and the overall well-being of the Western Balkans and beyond.

Among others, the financial support from IVF has been instrumental in the development and implementation of the Online Grant Management System.

This system has not only simplified the application process for potential grantees but has also enhanced project monitoring capabilities for WBF.



Since 2017, the Peace Nexus Foundation (PN) has recognised the Western Balkans Fund (WBF) as a promising collaborator and initiated a six-year partnership, establishing a strong foundation for joint endeavours and maintaining a collaborative partnership, actively working together to promote peace and regional integration in the Western Balkans.

The collaboration between PN and WBF has included targeted training programs and knowledge-sharing initiatives.

PN has provided the WBF Secretariat with valuable skills and insights to effectively address complex conflict dynamics and incorporate peace-oriented practices into its programs.

Moreover, WBF Secretariat has strengthened its essential tools, developed skills related to conflict-

sensitive and impactful approach within the WBF, fostering sustainable peacebuilding efforts throughout the region.

Guiding the development of a robust Monitoring, Evaluation, and Learning (MEL) system, PN gave a crucial impact in ensuring full accountability, transparency and a result-based approach.

Additionally, it refined and improved Human Resources (HR) policies and financial policies with clear guidelines for personnel management and financial governance.

PN's consistent and comprehensive support has played a pivotal role in significantly benefiting the Western Balkans Fund (WBF).

This close collaboration enabled WBF to exemplify the transformative power of strategic alliances in promoting peace, stability, and prosperity in the region.



Meeting with the Peace Nexus officials at our Secretariat

COOPERATION WITH OTHER LIKE-MINDED ORGANISATIONS

The Western Balkans Fund entertains close relations with many of the Regional Organisations. First and foremost, we have in place a Memorandum of Understanding and Growing Partnership with the Regional Youth Cooperation Office – RYCO.

Furthermore, we enjoy frequent exchanges with likeminded partners, including the Regional Cooperation Council (RCC), Regional Anti-Corruption Initiative (RAI), MARRI – Migration, Asylum, Refugees Regional Initiative, CEI – Central European Initiative, EUSAIR, etc.



Top: Meeting of the Heads of Regional Initiatives, "Prespa Dialogue Forum 2023", June 2023

Middle: WBF participating at the 7th EUSAIR Forum

Bottom: WBF Council of Senior Officials visit the RYCO Secretariat in Tirana





UNSTOPPABLE CONFERENCE

From 20-23 February 2023, it included a multitude of topics across the human rights spectrum, enhancing knowledge and strengthening the network of professionals coming from WB6 and V4 regions, also uniting diverse stakeholders, researchers, stories and case studies from all over the Region.

The advocacy event organized with the support of MOFA Japan and the IVF highlighted the importance of strengthening women's leadership as a burning issue for both regions. This critical issue resonated to organize a conference titled "Unstoppable: Women Overcoming Barriers to Success." The primary objective of this conference was to foster equal access to leadership positions in business, government, and non-profit organizations within the Western Balkans, the Visegrad region, and beyond.

The conference served as a platform to bring together distinguished leaders and experts from the region and beyond, both men and women, who contributed invaluable insights and perspectives.

Their collective contributions played a significant role in shaping a better future for gender equality within the Western Balkans region.

The conference facilitated meaningful discussions, shared experiences, and the exchange of best practices to address the barriers faced by women in pursuing leadership roles. With the inclusion of a diverse group of stakeholders, the conference managed to challenge existing norms and biases, promote inclusive decision-making processes, and advocate for the empowerment of women in all spheres of society.

Through collaborative efforts and shared commitment, the conference fostered an environment conducive to realizing a more equitable and



inclusive future, where women have equal opportunities to contribute to and lead in various sectors.

The Unstoppable conference was not just a simple event organized by the Western Balkans Fund; it was a multi-layered partnership involving governments, civil society, donors, the private sector, research organizations, and media organizations. It brought together 150 participants from Western Balkans and Visegrad Regions, as well EU and Japan, including a total of 3 Ministers of Foreign Affairs, 3 Ambassadors and 15 Embassy Representatives.



unstoppable

Do you know

On 30 June 2023, the Fund and the Ministry of Foreign Affairs of Japan decided to continue their cooperation by launching another important Conference, VerityCon 2023 – Navigating the Disinformation Era. Scheduled to take place in November, this remarkable event will connect preeminent experts and leaders who have placed combating disinformation at their agendas.

The action is foreseen as International-Regional Conference, providing space for dialogue among diverse stakeholders to discuss the topic. As the fifth experience of cooperation between the Fund and Japan, including a relevant contribution of IVF, we are confident in the success of such endeavour and the recommendations, conclusions including follow-up actions.



H.E. Takada, Ambassador of Japan to Albania and ED Murra sign the VerityCon agreement

Regional Networking

Representing our Region and making the case for reconciliation and more cooperation is very important for the Western Balkans Fund. In line with our mission and statute, the Fund has participated or hosted dozens of important regional events and meetings. During this reporting phase, the WBF has been to Berlin, Prague, Bratislava, Budapest and many other European capitals, always trying to promote the Western Balkans Region.



JUNE 22 - TIRANA & SHKODER INFO SESSIONS



JUNE 22 - SARAJEVO & TUZLA INFO SESSIONS



JUNE 22 - PODGORICA & NIKSIC INFO SESSIONS



JUNE 2022 - PRISHTINA & MITROVICA INFO SESSION



JUNE 22 - BELGRADE INFO SESSION



JUNE 22 - SKOPJE INFO SESSION



JUNE 22 - UN HABITAT FORUM



JULY 22 - VISIT TO IVF SECRETARIAT



SEPTEMBER 22 - DELEGATION OF NORTH MACEDONIAN MP VISITS THE SECRETARIAT



SEPTEMBER 22 - 5TH ANNIVERSARY OF WBF ESTABLISHMENT



OCTOBER 22 - AMBASSADOR OF JAPAN TO SKOPJE, H.E. SAWADA VISITS WBF



OCTOBER 22 - EU FOR YOUTH OPEN DAY



OCTOBER 22 - VISIT TO AMBASSADOR ITO IN SARAJEVO



NOVEMBER 22 - BERLIN PROCESS MEETING IN BERLIN



NOVEMBER 22 - VISIT TO THE BUNDESTAG



NOVEMBER 22 - WBF & UN CONFERENCE IN PRISTINA



**NOVEMBER 22 - SWISS
AMBASSADOR VISITS WBF**



DECEMBER 22 - TACSO MEETING IN BELGRADE



**DECEMBER 22 - AWARDING CEREMONY OF
THE 5TH CALL FOR PROPOSALS**



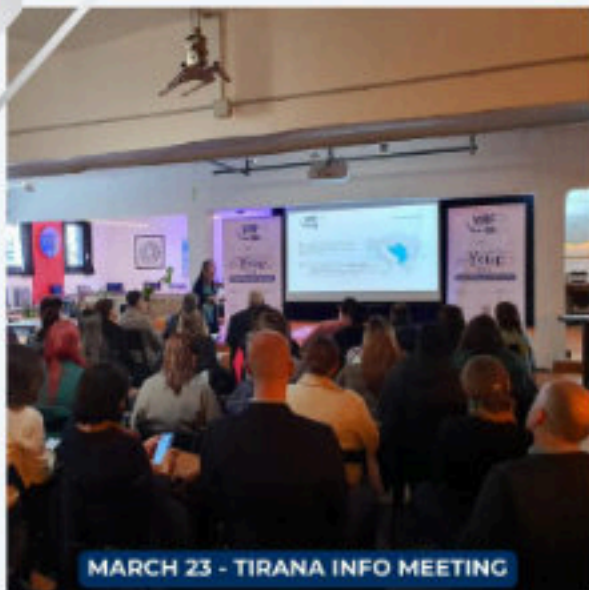
**JANUARY 23 - ELBASAN MAYOR
VISITS THE SECRETARIAT**



**FEBRUARY 23 - WORKING BREAKFAST
WITH V4 AMBASSADORS**



**FEBRUARY 23 - WBF JOINS THE
HUMANITARIAN RELIEF EFFORTS AFTER
DEADLY EARTHQUAKES IN TURKIYE & SYRIA**



MARCH 23 - TIRANA INFO MEETING



MARCH 23 - SARAJEVO INFO MEETING



MARCH 23 - PODGORICA INFO MEETING



MARCH 23 - SKOPJE INFO MEETING



MARCH 23 - PRISHTINA INFO MEETING



MARCH 23 - BELGRADE INFO MEETING



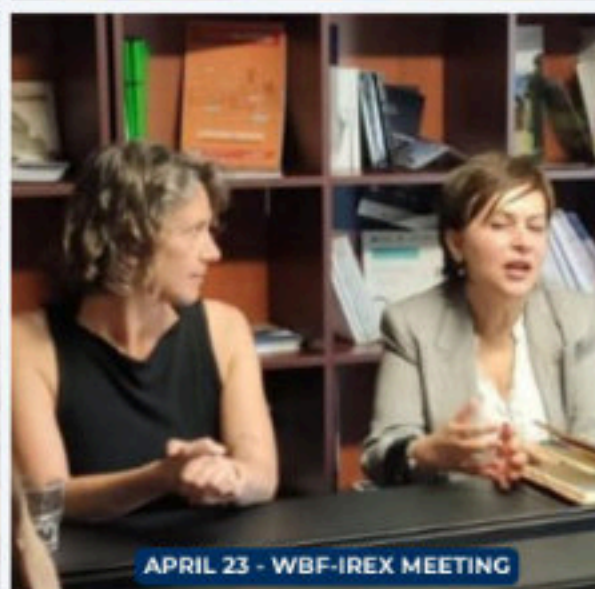
**MARCH 23 - WBF-EMBASSY
OF NORWAY MEETING**



MARCH 23 - BUDAPEST BALKANS FORUM



**APRIL 23 - MEETING WITH ALL THE SWISS
AMBASSADORS OF THE REGION**



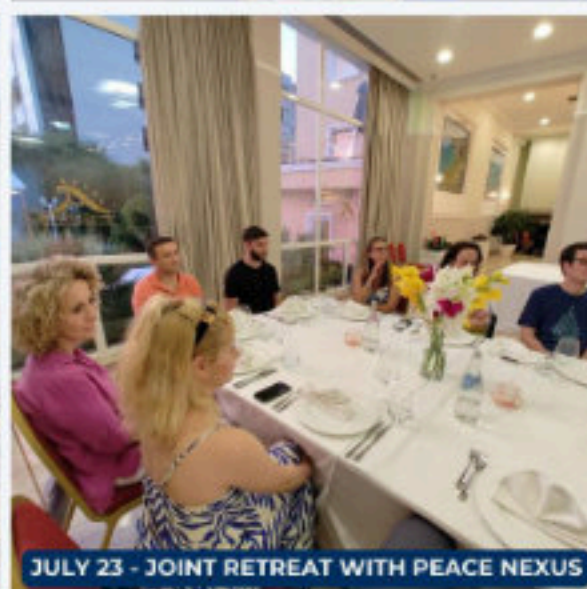
APRIL 23 - WBF-IREX MEETING



MAY - TACSO MEETING IN BELGRADE



JUNE - MEF FORUM IN SKOPJE





CHAPTER II

People to People Links

- **Annual Calls**
- **WBF-EU Joint Action**
- **WBF Move Grants**

Principle 2

WBF is available to all civil society and individuals' initiatives of the Region, regardless of their religious and/or any other beliefs, the language they use or any other personal characteristics.



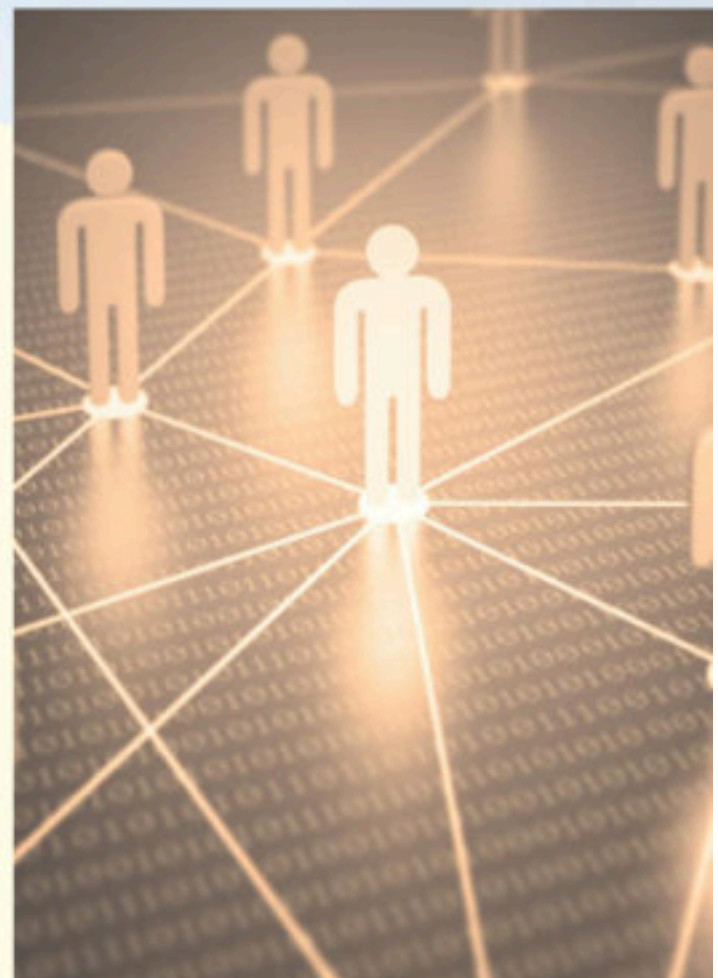
Grant-Giving
Schemes active
June 22-July 23



Grants awarded
during the
reporting period



Million Euros
available for
grants



WBF funding opportunities

The primary grant-giving scheme of the Western Balkans Fund is the Annual Calls. Since 2021, the Annual Call has been merged with the Joint Action, a mechanism co-funded by the European Union through IPA - Instrument for Pre-Accession Assistance.

Similarly to the first three Calls for Proposals (2018-2020), the 4th and 5th Calls have supported Civil Society Organizations and other eligible beneficiaries during 2021-23. The maximum amount provided by the Call for Proposals is 15,000 Euros per project.

A secondary scheme that supports organisations and, for the first time, individuals was launched in March 2023.

The WBF Move Grants are supported by the Swiss Agency for Cooperation and Development as part of a larger package aiming to strengthen and diversify the portfolio of WBF interventions.

The idea behind the Move Grants is to establish a yearly mechanism that supports regional mobility at short notice, 24/7.

The yearly Calls for Move Grants will open in March, June, and October. It supports organizations with up to 10,000 Euros and individuals with up to 5,000 Euros.



Financial Enveloppe of our Call for Proposals

1 Call for Proposals

240.000 €

2 Call for Proposals

260.000 €

3 Call for Proposals

250.000 €

4 Call for Proposals

400.000 €

5 Call for Proposals

500.000 €

Move Grants (2023)

210.000 €

Do you know that?

The WBF-EU Joint Action is funded 67.9% by the European Union and 32.1% by the core budget of the Western Balkans Fund.

The Fund has provided additional support in the form of logistics, network, salaries, staff and infrastructure

WBF-EU Joint Action



The Awarding
Ceremony
of the 5th Call
for Proposals



WBF launched the Fourth Call for Proposals (4 Cfp) on November 8th 2021, and remained open until December 27th and the Fifth Call on 20 May 2023 *(note. 4th and 5th Call correspond to 1st and 2nd Call co-funded by the EU).*

Both Calls encompassed three main areas of intervention: cultural cooperation, education and scientific exchanges, and sustainable development.

Within these three areas, applicants had a chance to explore and propose regional initiatives addressing one of the cross-cutting issues that included gender mainstreaming, equal opportunities, the empowerment of minorities and vulnerable groups, environmental sustainability, climate change mitigation and adaptation, and more.

Within the framework of this Call, WBF implemented regional projects in various timelines from 3 to 10 months, allowing ample time for project teams to achieve their goals and create a meaningful impact in the Region.

The action in Numbers

24 Regional Info Sessions

69 regional awarded grants

267 awarded stakeholders

375 eligible applications

714 total applications

2.000+ partnerships
established

900.000 Euros in grants

7.4 million Euros requested

WBF announced winners of 4 CFP in March and celebrated the success of this Call with 30 regional grant winners from the Region on 14-15 April 2022 in Tirana to the Award Ceremony and Partnership Workshop.

The winners of the 5 CFP were announced in 2 December 2022, with the Awarding Ceremony and ensuing mentoring sessions on 19-20 December 2023.

At the time of this reporting, the 4CFP is fully closed, while projects of the 5CFP are still in their implementation stage.

“

The Joint Action of the European Union and the Western Balkans Fund serves the European Union agenda in the Western Balkans and reflects our values and aspirations.

We expect this cooperation to enable the grassroots organisation to engage in regional cooperation, positively impacting good neighbourly relations and reconciliation, and have a greater role in the accession reforming processes

H.E. Luigi Soreca,
EU Ambassador to Tirana




The Awarding
Ceremony
of the 4th Call
for Proposals

The Call was open on May 20th, remaining open until July 5th. The evaluation occurred in autumn, with the Awarding Ceremony and Partnership Workshop 19-20 December 2022.

Implementation started immediately in January 2023.

Do you know that?

After the very successful 4th and 5th Co-funded Call for Proposals, the Western Balkans Fund and European Union have agreed in principle to prolong the cooperation for two more years.

List of Projects

WBF 4th Call for Proposals

Media and art in service of reconciliation / Association Kulturana	Balkan Shorts Film Network / UG Akademika Soana	Promoting the Western Balkans greenways network / Yugo Cycling Campaign
Mainstreaming Humanity in Western Balkans: From Education to Reconciliation / Faculty of Political Science, University of Belgrade	Balchestra / ArtLink	In Search of Our Musical Roots / Umjetnost djece-Jazz Art
Contemporary Fortresses of Culture: Boka, Trolinje, Novi Sad / Don Branko Subtega Foundation	Birds Without Borders (BWB)- Phase II Center for Protection and Research of Birds (CZIP)	Partnership for mothers and babies / Gradjaniki gles Cma Gare
Intercultural dialogue for joint past narrative / Youth initiative for Human rights Montenegro	Game Jan / IPKO Foundation	Enhancing Regional Cooperation of Young Researchers on Migration & Development / GERMIN
Support to women's efforts in building regional democracy / Kosovo Institute of Media and Communication	I love Balkan / NGO Lady	Regional Investment Promotion / Chamber of Doing Business in Kosovo*
Regional evenings of cultural heritage / Ensemble of folk dances and songs "VESELIN MASLESA"	The green valley / IPSIA BBH	Cross Border Coworking Cooperation (CBCC) / INTERA Technology Park
Female leadership Camp / Udrutenje Otvorene zabavne škole	Messages from the past / Zenica City Museum	Transitional justice - through joint educational approach / ANIM - History Teacher Association of Macedonia
Ohrid Tread Athletic Camp 2022 / Athletic Club Ohrid tread	Leap to success / AGORA	Common Cultural Heritage: interregional research and educational practices / Center for Prehistoric Research
Protection of natural and cultural heritage trough sustainable tourism in potential geoparks PRONACTUR / Stenastenas	Art for Reconciliation / Tulla culture center	Strengthening intercultural dialogue as a tool for youth-to-youth connection and good neighborly relations in the region / AFCR
QAR - (Qendra Artizanale Rrora) / Association Tirana Elapres	Hello Neighbour: Knowing the region through internships and exchange / Impact Centre	Creating a cross-border network for socio-economic sustainability through protection of nature / FLAG

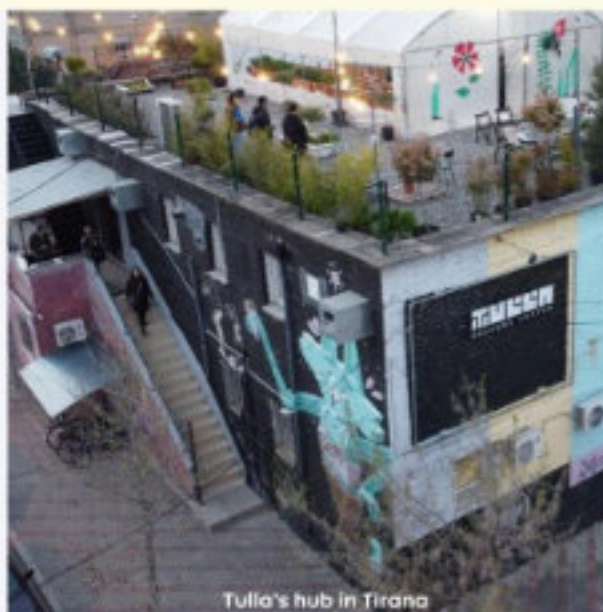
* This designation is without prejudice to positions on status, and is in line with UNSCR 1244/1999 and the ICJ Opinion on the Kosovo declaration of independence

Art for Reconciliation

A project led by **Tulla Culture Center** | Tirana

Partners | **Centar za Urban Razvoj** in Belgrade and **Prifilm Festival** in Prishtina.

Activities took place in Tirana, Belgrade and Prishtina



Tulla's hub in Tirana



Artlink side-event in Kotor, Montenegro

Balchestra

A project led by **Artlink Association** | Belgrade

Partners | **Artplus** in Tirana, **Association for Affirmation of Musical Culture** in Skopje and **International Peace Center** in Sarajevo.

Activities took place in Belgrade, Prizren, Tirane, Skopje, Kotor and Sarajevo.

Balkan Shorts Film Network

A project led by **UG Akademaska Scena** | Bajina Basta

Partners | **Association for cultural affirmation Bager Genesis 2.0** in Struga and **NVO Ja Djelujem** in Ulcinj.

Activities took place in Bajina Basta, Struga and Ulcinj.



Illustrative Picture from the Basta Fest

Bird's Without Borders

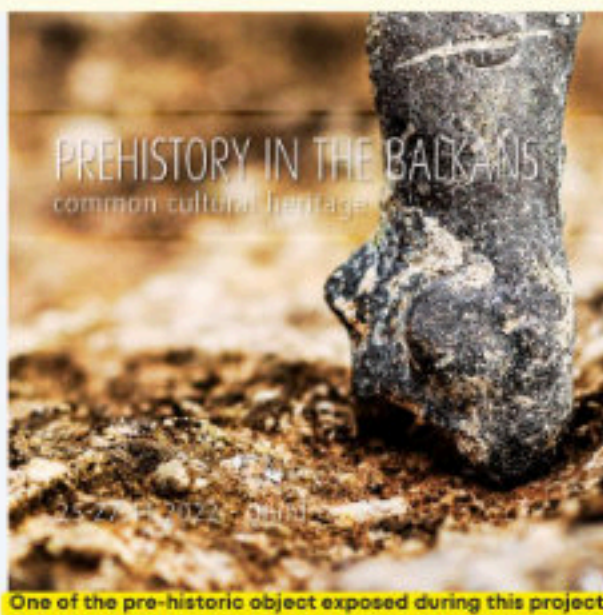
A project led by "CZIP" | Spuz

Partners | **Bird Protection and Research Society of Serbia** in Belgrade and **Albanian Ornithological Society** in Tirana.

Activities took place in Ulcinj, Saranda and Kikinda.



Installing a GPS tracker at a Stork in Saranda Camp



One of the pre-historic object exposed during this project

Common Cultural Heritage: Interregional Research and educational practices

A project led by Center for Prehistoric Research | Skopje

Partners | **Institute of Archaeology, Academy for Albanian Studies** in Tirana and **Faculty of Philosophy** in Belgrade.

Activities took place in Bregalnica (Vlaho site Pelagonia), Vinca, Piva and Pogradec.

Creating a Cross-Border Network for socio-economic sustainability

A project led by FLAG Association | Tirana.

Partners | **Agency for Management of Protected Areas of Podgorica and Environment and Youth Capacity Development, EYCD** in Prishtina.

Activities took place in Podgorica, Prishtina, Tirana and Shkoder.



FLAG Final Conference

Contemporary Fortresses of Culture

A project led by Don Branko Sbutega Foundation | Kotor.

Partners | **Društvo građana Podbare "Almašani"** in Novi Sad and **Udruga građana "Mostovi"** Trebinje.

Activities took place in Kotor, Trebinje and Novi Sad.



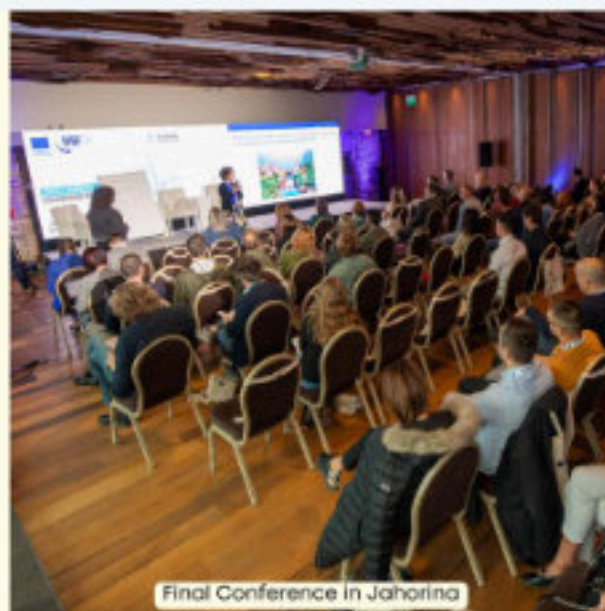
Military bands playing in Kotor during the implementation of the project

Cross-Border co-working cooperation

A project led by Intera Technological Park | Mostar.

Partners | **Proaktiv Organisation** based in Nis and **Innovation and Entrepreneurship Center Tehnopolis** based in Niksic.

Activities took place in Mostar, Jahorina, Niksic and Nis.



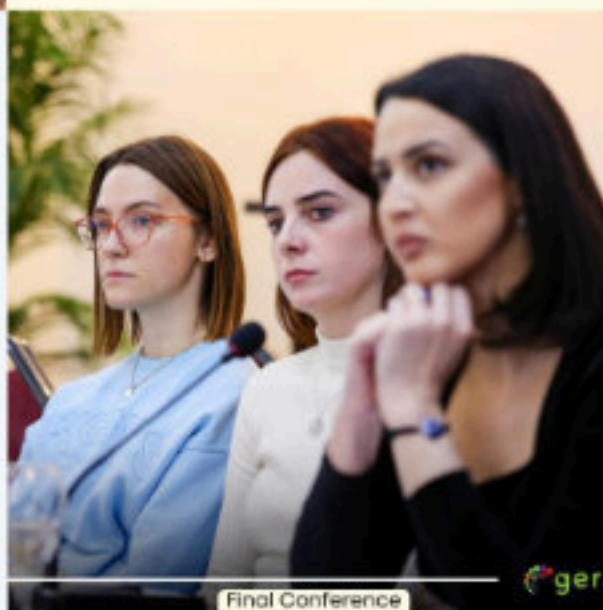
Final Conference in Jahorina

Enhancing Regional Cooperation of Young Researchers on Migration

A project led by GERMIN | Prishtina

Partners | **Center for Support of Local and Regional Development CeP** in Herceg Novi and **Association Estima** in Bitola.

Activities took place in Prishtina, Podgorica, Herceg Novi, Bitola and Skopje.



Final Conference

Female Leadership Camp

A project led by **Fun Schools Association** | Sarajevo.

Partners | **FK Breznica** in Pljevlja and **Open Schools** in Belgrade.

Activities took place in Pljevlja and Sarajevo.



Picture taking during the leadership session in Pljevlja

Game Jam

A project led by **IPKO Foundation** | Prishtina.

Partners | **Cyber Security, Corporate Security and Crisis Management Initiative – C3I** in Skopje and **WIT Center** in Tirana.

Activities took place in Prishtina.



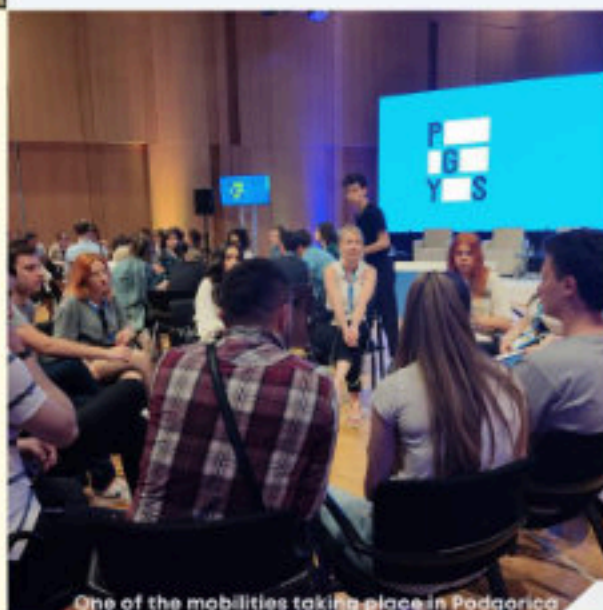
Organisers in Prishtina

Hello Neighbour

A project led by **Impact Centre** in Tirana.

Partners | **Media Promo Info** in Casin and **Youth Initiative for Human Rights** in Montenegro.

Activities took place in Korca, Vlora, Skrapar, Lushnja, Lezha, Tirana, Podgorica, Niksic, Budva, Rozaje, Tuzla, Sarajevo, Cazin, and Zenica.



One of the mobilities taking place in Podgorica

I Love Balkan

A project led by NGO Lady | Prishtina.

Partners | **Observatory for Children and Youth Human Rights** in Tirana; **Poduzetnice In** in Sarajevo; **Association of Women Entrepreneurs of Montenegro** in Podgorica; **Macedonian Women's Rights Centre – Shelter Centre** Skopje; **Association of Women Filigran Art** in Kragujevac and **Balkan Women Association** in Prishtina.

Activities took place in Prishtina



Final Conference took place in Prishtina

In Search of Our Musical Roots

A project led by Jazz Art Association | Podgorica.

Partners | **Academy of Music at Golce Delceu University of Stip**, **Syri Blue Association** in Tirana, **Academy of Arts of the University of Banja Luka** and **University of Arts in Belgrade**.

Activities took place in Podgorica, Tirana and Banja Luka.



Picture taken during one of the events in the CPs

Intercultural Dialogue for Joint Past narrative and Reconcilliation

A project led by **Youth Initiative for Human Rights Montenegro** | Podgorica

Partners, **Youth Initiative for Human Rights in Bosnia and Hercegovina** in Sarajevo and **Youth Initiative for Human Rights in Serbia**, based in Belgrade.

Activities took place in Podgorica, Sarajevo and Belgrade.



Picture taken during the implementation of the project

Intercultural Dialogue: A tool for youth to youth connection

A project led by **Albanian Foundation for Conflict Resolution and Reconciliation of Disputes** | Tirana.

Partners | **Association Interactive Education and Resource Network - IMOR** in Bitola and **Nansen Dialogue Centre** Mostar.

Activities took place in Durrës, Bitola and Mostar.



Leap to Success

A project led by **AGORA Organisation** | Skopje

Partners | **Metropolitan Incubator** in Tirana and **Deli Space for Creative Activity** in Nis.

Activities took place in Ohrid.



Mainstreaming Humanity in the Western Balkans

A project led by **Faculty of Political Sciences, University of Belgrade**

Partners | **Humanistic Studies of the University of Donja Gorica** in Podgorica; **Belgrade International Law Circle** and **Faculty of Political Sciences University of Sarajevo**

Activities took place in Belgrade.



Media and Art in service of Reconciliation

A project led by **Kulturanova** | Petrovaradin, Novi Sad.

Partners | **"Our Children" Association** in Zenica and **Art and Community Center Artpolis** in Prishtina.

Activities took place in Srebrenica, Zenica and Novi Sad



Messages from the Past

A project led by **Zenica City Museum** | Zenica.

Partners | **Montenegrin Academy of Social Sciences** in Bijelo Polje and **Library Slovo** in Lapovo.

Activities took place in Zenica.

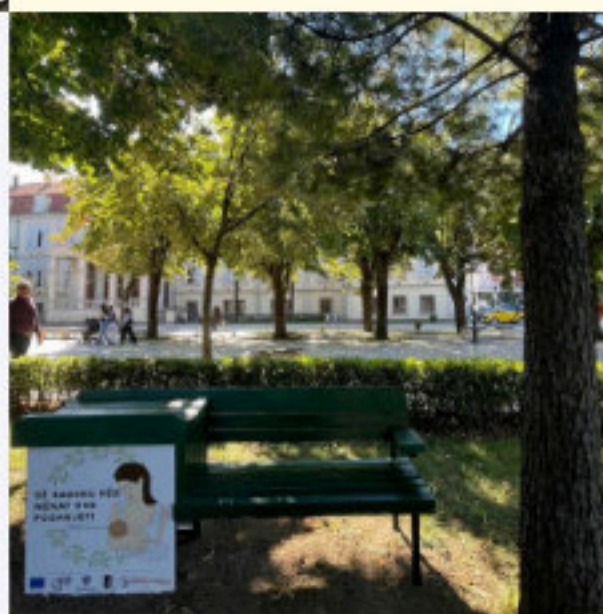


Partnership for Mother and Babies

A project led by **Gradjanski Glas Montenegro** | Budva.

Partners | **Fondacija Zenski Centar** in Trebinje and **Women to Women Association** in Shkodra.

Activities took place in Bar, Shkodër and Trebinje.



Promoting the Western Balkans greenways

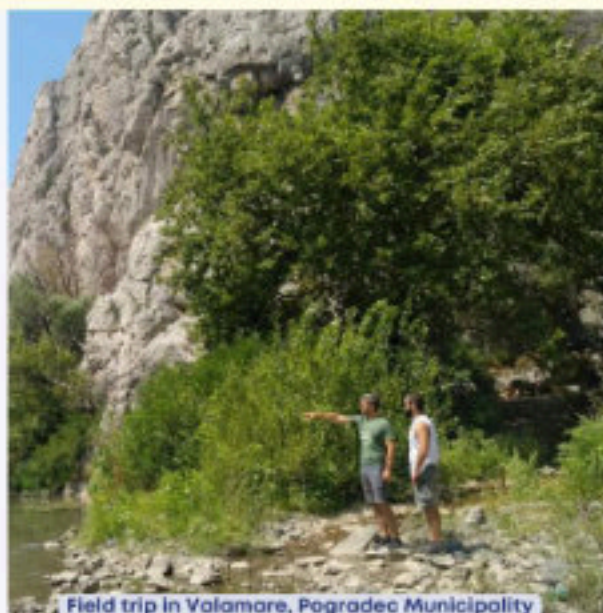
A project led by **YUGO Cycling** | Belgrad

Partners | **NU Nature Lovers** in Niksic and the **Mountain Biking Association** in Mostar.

Activities took place in Priboj, Uvac, Herceg Novi and Trebinje.



Picture taken in Herceg Novi during the Implementation



Field trip in Valamare, Pogradec Municipality

Protection of Natural and Cultural Heritage

A project led by **Stena Stenae** | Demir Kapija.

Partners, **Municipality of Demir Kapija**, **Department of Geography and tourism of the Novi Sad University**; **Birds of Albania** in Tirana and **Park Piva** in Pluzine.

Activities took place in Demir Kapija, Park Piva and Valamara protected area near Pogradec.

Regional Evenings of cultural heritage

A project led by the **Ensemble of folk dances and songs "Veselin Maslesa"** | Banja Luka

Partners, **Academic Cultural Artistic Association "SPANAC"** in Belgrade and the **Folklore Ensemble of dance and song "Skopje"** - Skopje

Activities took place in Banja Luka, Beograd and Ohrid.



Illustrative Picture from the "Veselin Maslesa" Ensemble

Regional Investment Promotion

A project led by **Chamber of Trade and Industry of Kosovo** | Prishtina.

Partners, **Economic Chamber of Northwest Macedonia** in Skopje and **Chamber of Economy of Montenegro** in Podgorica.

Activities took place in Prishtina, Podgorica and Skopje.



Illustrative picture from the past joint events between the Chamber and the Fund

Support to Women's effort in building regional democracy

A project led by **Kosovo Institute of Media and Communication** | Prishtina

Partners, **Gradjanski Glas** in Budva and **Mediator Room** in Belgrade.

Activities took place in Prishtina.



Family picture from the final event

The Green Valley

A project led by **IPSIA BiH** | Sarajevo.

Partners, **Volonterski centar Vojvodine** in Novi Sad and **GAIA** in Prishtina.

Activities took place in Sarajevo, Novi Sad and Prishtina.



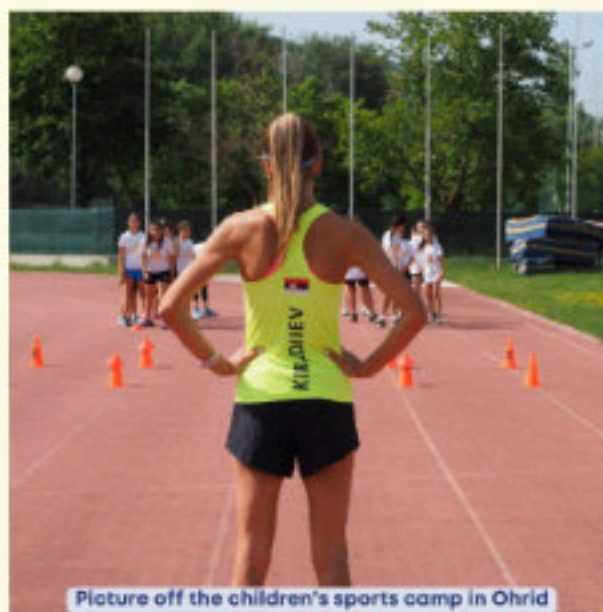
From the IPSIA BiH activities

Ohrid Treat Athletic Club

A project led by **Athletic Club Ohrid
Treat** | Ohrid.

Partners, **Association Zdrav Zivot-
Kinezis** in Mostar; **Trail Running
Albania** in Tirana; **AK Hajduk-Maraton
Tim Kula** in Kula and **AK Rabotnicki** in
Skopje.

Activities took place in Ohrid.



Picture off the children's sports camp in Ohrid



In Picture, products build by the disabled
children participating at this project

Youth Artisanal Centre

A project led by **Association
Tirana Ekspres** | Tirana.

Partners, **Artlab** in Sarajevo and **NGO
Creative and Active** in Struga.

Activities took place in Tirana, Mostar
and Struga.

Strengthening intercultural dialogue as a tool for youth- to-youth connection

A project led by **Albanian Foundation for
Conflict Resolution and Reconciliation
of Disputes** | Tirana

Partners, **Association Interactive
Education and Resource Network –
IMOR** in Bitola and **Nansen Dialogue
Centre** Mostar.

Activities took place in Tirana, Durrës,
Mostar, Prilep and Bitola.



From the implementation in Durrës

List of Projects

5th Call for Proposals

Regional Youth Festival "Little Night Music" – Kancelarija za gradsko Kragujevac	Regional cooperation of scientists and young researchers from the WB in mammalian ecology Ecology and Research Association	Talk with me! Center for Global Health
Miredita, Dobro Dan! – Youth Initiative for Human Rights Serbia	Western Balkans Ideathon Foundation 787	Improved inclusion at basic education in the Western Balkans through sharing of experiences Edgward
Intercultural Learning for All – Association Halfway There	Western Balkan Handball Youth Cup Rukometni klub Borac m16	Tailoring the Future for Women in the WB Region Bardha Association
Interaction Teen Doc Workshop 2023 Towards a Better Region/ Independent Film Centre FilmArt	Future4Roots Agricultural Cluster SRP	Folktronika: Re-imagining Balkan Folk Music through Technology S.M.A.SH
Open Western Balkan Collaboratory on Online Platform Work: Serbia, Albania and Bosnia & Herzegovina Public Policy Research	"We are creating a better future" Public Institution Secondary Technical School	Regional empowerment of women, promotion and protection of traditional artisan products NGO Equality
WB-cities creating more opportunities for young people Local Democracy Agency Subotica	Connecting Makerspaces in the Western Balkans Region Association "Digital Fabrication Laboratory"	Game Jam Prizren IPKO Foundation
Summer School for Future (STE)M leaders Faculty of Mathematics and Natural Science, University of Montenegro	Youth Kult Zone Youth Alliance	Enhancing security through energy alliance "A joint Action" Albanian Institute for International Studies
Accused Mountains, Cross Border Science Classroom NGO Green Home	"Let's create music together" OOMU "Ordan Mihajloski-Ocke"	Solar energy for citizens in Western Balkans Friends of Kerpa
ARYSE Juventus	"Kids Classical Music Camp" Association of pianists and music pedagogues	Girls – The game changers of politics! Albanian Institute of Public Affairs AIPA
Local Communities Climate Adaptation and Resilience "Lecora" Centre for Climate Change, Natural Resources & Energy of University of Danja Gorica	Reversing the brain drain through the Scientific Diaspora in the Western Balkans RRGSH	Promoting Collaboration Between SMEs and Civil Society in the light against corruption Albanian Center for Economic Research ACER
Bioinforming the Youth NVO Bioinformatika	Advancing regional cooperation and the EU integration through the Think Balkan's Initiative Institute for Democracy "Societas Civilis"	Say and Do Green! – SEDA
Research Station, "International Summer School" Montenegrin Science Promotion Foundation "PRONA"	Astronautism – Fostering STEM and SDGI Center for Education and Innovative Learning – STEMlab	"People to People, in music we trust" – Social Contract Institute

Accursed Mountains - Crossorder Science Classroom

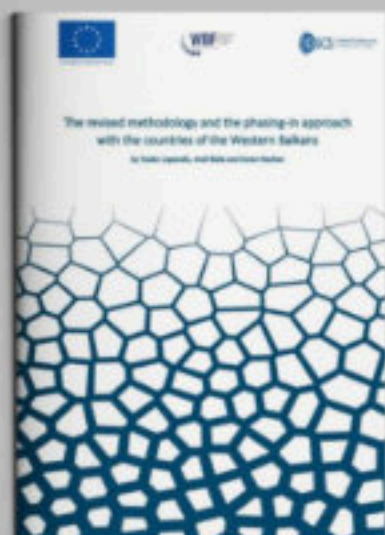
A project led by **NGO Green Home** |
Podgorica

Partners, **Environmentally Responsible
Action (ERA)** in Peja and **Institute for
Nature Conservation Albania** in Tirana.

Activities taking place in Grebaje Valley,
Plav.



From the camp in Grebaje Mountain



Publication of the project's findings

Advancing regional cooperation and EU integration through the Think Balkan's initiative

A project led by **Institute for
Democracy Societas Civilis** | Skopje

With partners **Evropski pokret u
Srbiji (EPuS)/ European Movement
Serbia** in Belgrade and **Albanian
Institute for International Studies**.

Activities taking place in Skopje,
Tirana and Belgrade

Astrotourism - Fostering STEM and SDG!

A project led by **STEMLab** | Tetovo

With partners **Edu Act** in Tirana,
Universi in Prishtina and **Stem
Academy** in Tuzla.

Activities taking place in Tetovo.



From the concluding Conference held in Tetovo

Aryse

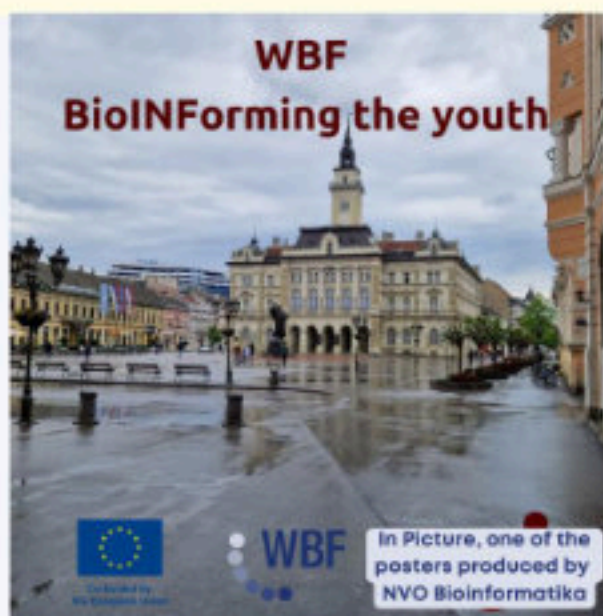
A project led by **Juventas** | Podgorica

Partners, **PREVENT** in Novi Sad; **NGO Labyrinth** in Prishtina; **Initiative for Local Change (ARSIS)** in Tirana and **Healthy Option Protect** Skopje.

Activities taking place in Podgorica.



Illustrative picture from past events of NGO Juventas



Bioinforming the Youth

A project led by **NVO Bioinformatika** | Herceg Novi

Partners | **EduSmart** in Belgrade; **The Higher Education Technical School of Professional Studies** in Novi Sad and **Mother Teresa University** in Skopje.

Activities taking place in Skopje and Novi Sad.

Connecting Makerspaces in the Western Balkans Region

A project led by **Association Digital Fabrication Laboratory** | Sarajevo

Partners | **Foster Association – Stip**; **Innovation business center Zlatibor** and **Science Technology Park Cacak**.

Activites taking place in:



Picture taken during the implementation in Sarajevo

Enhancing security through energy alliance - A joint Action

A project led by **Albanian Institute for International Studies** | Tirana.

Partners | **European Policy Institute (EPI)** in Skopje and **Democracy for Development (D4D)** in Prishtina.

Activities taking place in Tirana, Prishtina and Skopje.



AIIS Conference

Folktronika: Re-imagining Balkan Folk Music through Technology

A project led by **S.M.A.SH** | Prishtina.

Partners | **Jadro Social Cultural Space** in Skopje; **Society of Multimedial Artists for Secession and Humanities** in Prishtina and **Destil Creative Hub** in Tirana.

Activities taking place in Prishtina, Skopje and Tirana.



Cover Picture of Folk Musicians in Gjirokastrë

Future4Roots

A project led by **Agricultural Cluster SRP** | East Sarajevo.

Partners | **Agro-klastar Srbije** in Novi Sad; **Women Association Eva** in Rudo; **KUD Slavija** in East Sarajevo; **Secondary School "28. juni"** in East Sarajevo; **Association "Romanijski skorup-kajmak"** Han Pijesak; **Association of mountain sports club RUEN** Kriva Palanka.

Activities taking place in East Sarajevo, Novi Sad and Skopje



Agricultural products showcased during the implementation

Game Jam Prizren

A project led by **IPKO Foundation** | Prishtina.

Partners | **Empower Society Albania (ESA)** in Tirana and **Woman4Cyber** North Macedonia in Skopje.

Activities taking place in Prizren.



From Game Jam VIII edition held in Prizren

Girls - the game changers of politics!

A project led by **Albanian Institute of Public Affairs – AIPA** | Tirana.

Partners | **NGO “Djeca Crne Gore”** in Tuzi and **Lifelong Learning Network** in Tetovo.

Activities taking place in Tirana, Tuzi and Tetovo.



Workshop held at the Municipality of Tuzi

Improved inclusion at basic education in the Western Balkans through sharing of experiences

A project led by **EdGuard Institute** | Prishtina.

Partners | **Child Rights Centre Albania** in Tirana and **Center for Education and Development** in Tearce.

Activities taking place in Prishtina, Tetovo, Tirana, Tearce.



Participating teachers receive their diploma on inclusiveness

Interaction Teen Doc Workshop 2023 Towards a Better Region

A project led by **Independent Film Centre Filmart** | Pozega, Cacak, Uzice and Belgrade

Partners | **SEEcult.org Portal for SEE Culture and Art** in Belgrade, **Crnogorski Filmski Festival** in Podgorica, **Kinoklub Karlovac** in Croatia, **Udruženje "Produkcija Prvi kadar"**, East Sarajevo; **CSO Klara and Rosa** in Subotica and **Winter Apricot** – Prilep.

Activities taking place in three Contracting Parties plus Croatia



Representatives of the Filmart sign the grant contract during the workshop held in December 2022

Intercultural learning for all

A project led by **Association Halfway There** | Pancevo

Partners | **SUMERO - Union of Organizations for Support to the Persons with Intellectual Disability of FBiH** in Sarajevo and **PORAKA - Republic Center for Support of Persons with Intellectual Disability** in Skopje.

Activities taking place in Skopje.



Participants of the project events in Skopje

Kids Classical Music Camp

A project led by **Association of Pianists and Music Pedagogues Piano** | Bitola

Partners | **Udruženje Sirmium Gradus ad Parnassum** in Sremska Mitrovica and **"Tefta Tashko Koco" High School** in Korça.

Activities taking place in Bitola, Ohrid and Pelister.



Participants of the camp in Bitola

Let's create music together

A project led by **Municipal Primary Music School "Ordan Mihajloski-Ocka"** primary music school "Ordan Mihajloski-Ocka" | Prilep.

Partners | **Elementary music school "Davorin Jenko"** in Belgrade and **Public entity - School for Elementary Musical education "Istочно Sarajevo"** in East Sarajevo.

Activities taking place in Prilep, Belgrade and East Sarajevo.



Participants in Prilep



In Picture, a poster of the project

Local Communities' Climate Adaptation and Resilience #LOCCAR#

A project led by **Centre for Climate Change, Natural Resources and Energy of University of Donja Gorica** | Podgorica

Partners | **Regional Environmental Center** in Sarajevo and **Environmental Ambassadors for Sustainable Development** Belgrade.

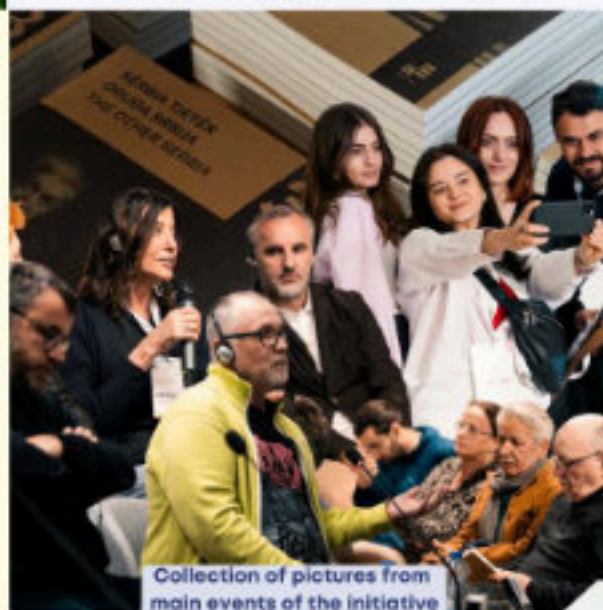
Activities taking place in Podgorica

Miredita, Dobar dan!

A project led by **Youth Initiative for Human Rights Serbia** | Belgrade

Partners | **Inicijativa mladih za ljudska prava u BiH** in Sarajevo, **Integra in Prishtina** and **Civic Initiatives** in Belgrade.

Activities taking place in Prishtina and Belgrade.



Collection of pictures from main events of the initiative

Open Western Balkan Collaboratory on Online Platform Work

A project led by **Public Policy Research
Centre** | Belgrade

Partners | **Public University "Luigj
Gurakuqi"** Shkodër and **Association for
Social, Cultural and Creative
Development Zora** in Zenica.

Activities taking place in Belgrade



People to People - In Music We Trust

A project led by **Social Contract
Institute** | Tirana.

Partners | **Odjek Chamber Choir** in
Pozarevac and **Pro Ars** in Skopje.

Activities taking place in Tirana and
Skopje.

Promoting Collaboration Between SMEs and Civil Society in the Fight Against Corruption

A project led by **Albanian Center for
Economic Research (ACER)** | Tirana

Partners | **Institute for Corruption
Research (KAREYAS)**, Pancevo and
**Organization for Democracy, Anti-
Corruption and Dignity - ÇOHU!** in
Prishtina.

Activities taking place in Tirana, Belgrade
and Prishtina



Regional cooperation of scientists and young researchers from the W.B in the field of mammalian ecology

A project led by Ecology and Research Association (EID) | Banja Luka.

Partners | **PPNEA** in Tirana; **ERA** in Peja; **CZIP** Podgorica; **MES** in Skopje; **Faculty of Sciences, University of Novi Sad** (FSUNS); **WLMNE** in Podgorica; **CKS** in Sarajevo; **TMSBIH** in Ilidza.

Activities taking place in Volujak and Banja Luka.



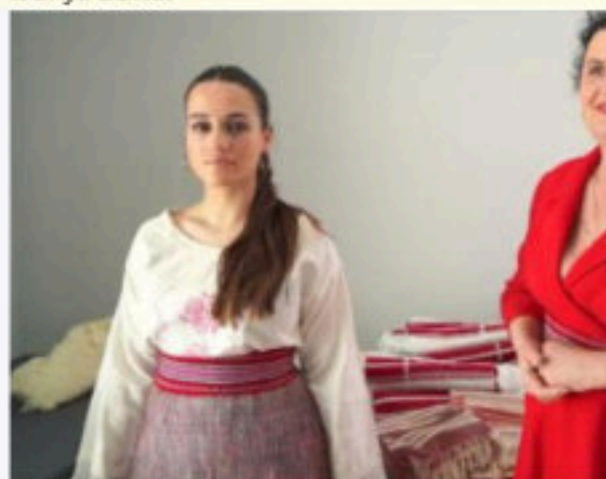
Illustrative picture from past events of EID

Regional empowerment of women – promotion and protection of traditional artisan products

A project led by **NVO Equality** | Prizren

Partners | **Association “Pazarski Bazar Ruktvorina”** Novi Pazar; **Women in Public Service Center** in Tirana.

Activities taking place in Prizren and Durrës.



YOUTUBE.COM

Youtube documentary produced on the framework of this project

Regional empowerment of women – promotion and protection of traditional artisan products project

Regional youth festival “Little Night Music”

A project led by **Youth Chancellery of the City of Kragujevac**

Partners | **Municipality of Bar**, **Municipality of Foča** and **Municipality of Ohrid**

Activities taking place in all the involved Municipalities.



Participants visit the Municipality of Kragujevac

Research station - International Summer School

A project led by **Montenegrin Science Promotion Foundation "PRONA"** | Podgorica

Partners | **NGO Osvezenje** in Pirot and **GAUSS Institute – Foundation for New Technologies, Innovations, and Knowledge Transfer** in Bitola.

Activities taking place in Ivanova Korita, Cetinje.



Picture of the International Summer School



Final Conference in Skopje

Reversing the brain drain through the Scientific Diaspora in the Western Balkans

A project led by **RRGSH** | Skopje.

Partners | **Institute for Strategic Studies and Prognoses** in Podgorica, **GERMIN** in Prishtina and **Center for Economic and Social Studies (CESS)** in Tirana.

Activities taking place in Skopje.

Say and Do Green!

A project led by **Sustainable Economic Development Agency (SEDA)** | Tirana.

Partners | **Ecological Network of Montenegro** in Bar and **Institute for Good Governance and Policy in Environment and Climate Change (IPECC)** in Skopje.

Activities taking place in Durrës, Podgorica and Skopje.



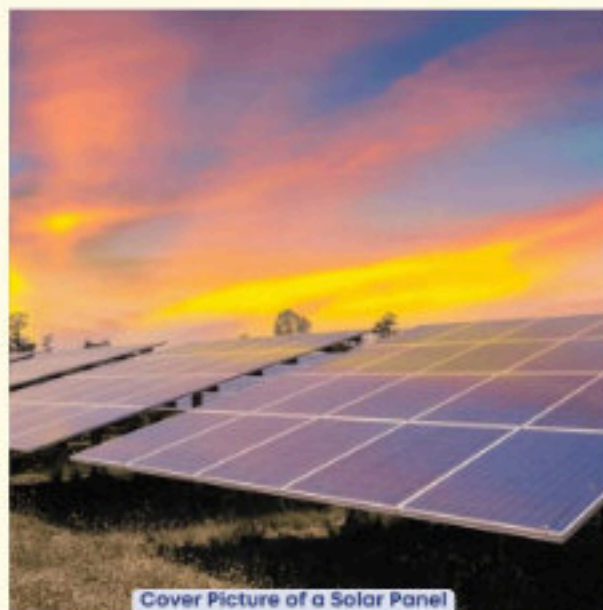
Citizens write on the blackboard of SEDA in Durrës

Solar energy for citizens in Western Balkans

A project led by **Friends of Korca Association** | Korçë

Partners | **Tirana Politechnical University**, **Albanian Association of Renewable Energy (AREA)** in Tirana, **Korca University**, **Balkan WASH Network (BWN)** in Skopje, **Fond za Inovacije Cerne Gore** in Podgorica, **CSCD** in Debar, **MSJA** in Ulcinj and **EASD** in Belgrade.

Activities taking place in Tirana



Cover Picture of a Solar Panel



Cover Picture, University of Montenegro

Summer School for Future (STE)M leaders

A project led by **University of Montenegro, Faculty of Mathematics and Natural Sciences** | Podgorica.

Partners | **Universiteti "Ismael Qemali"** in Vlora; **Mathematical Institute of the Serbian Academy of Sciences and Arts** in Belgrade; **University of East Sarajevo**, **University of Mostar, Faculty of Natural and Educational Sciences** at Ss Cyril and Methodius University, **Faculty of Natural Sciences and Mathematics** in Skopje.

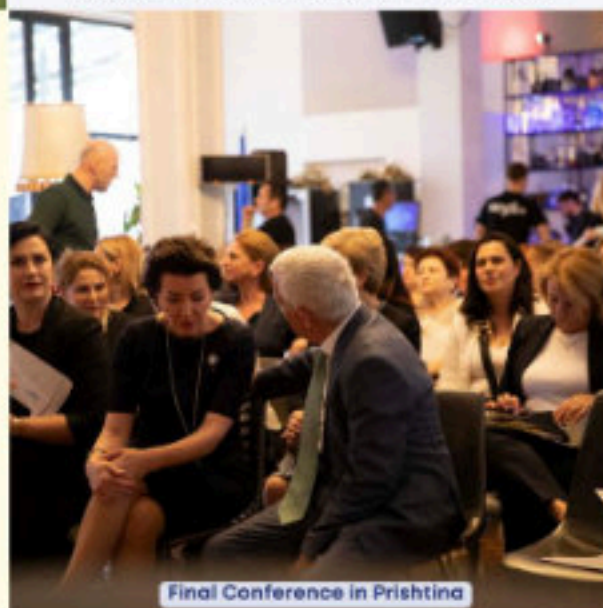
Activities taking place in Petrovac.

Tailoring the Future for Women in WB Region

A project led by **Bardha Association** | Prishtina.

Partners | **Trade Association Textile Cluster** in Skopje and **Center for Excellence Destiny** in Tirana.

Activities taking place in Prishtina



Final Conference in Prishtina

Talk with Me!

A project led by **Center for Global Health** | Prishtina.

Partners | **Center for Research and Project Implementation** in Tirana and **Synopsis World** in Skopje.

Activities taking place in Prishtina, Tirana and Skopje.



WB cities creating more opportunities for young people

A project led by **Local Democracy Agency** | Subotica

Partners | **Local Democracy Agency Montenegro** in Niksic and **Local Democracy Agency** Prijedor.

Activities taking place in Subotica, Novi Sad, Niksic and Prijedor.

"We are creating a better future"

A project led by **Public Institution Secondary Technical School** | Tesanj

Partners | **Technical School Cacak** and **Mixed Secondary School "Mladost"** in Tivat.

Activities taking place in Tesanj



West Balkan Handball Youth Cup

A project led by **ORK Borac** | Banja Luka

Partners | **RK Gračanica** in Gračanica;
RK Crvena Zvezda in Belgrade; **RK Lovćen** in Cetinje

Activities taking place in Banja Luka



Crvena Zvezda team participating at the Cup



Members of Foundation 787 and other grantees receive their Grant Awards Certificate in Tirana

Western Balkan Ideathon

A project led by **Foundation 787** | Sarajevo.

Partners | **Digital Den** in Podgorica and **Association of Young Entrepreneurs of Serbia** in Belgrade.

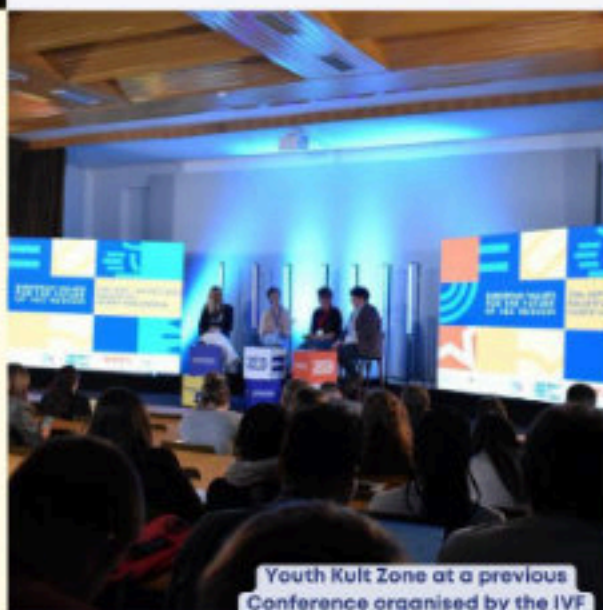
Activities taking place in Sarajevo

Youth Kult Zone

A project led by **Youth Alliance** | Krusevo.

Partners | **Young Professionals Network** in Tirana, **PS "MAYA"- Educational Center** in Travnik, **Center for Education and Training** Prizren, **Tim za Razvoj i Integracije** in Vranje and **Youth Cultural Centre** in Herceg Novi.

Activities taking place in all the Western Balkans Region.



Youth Kult Zone at a previous Conference organised by the IVF

The WBF Move Grants



Tirana Info Meeting

In 2023, the Western Balkans Fund (WBF) reached a significant milestone by diversifying grants for the region through the implementation of MOVE Grants.

This achievement underscores WBF's dedication to fostering regional development, cooperation, and inclusivity.

Designed as a dynamic and flexible rolling mechanism, MOVE Grants bring the Western Balkans Fund (WBF) closer to the people and communities of the region.

Embracing this approach, WBF ensures that ideas and needs are addressed promptly and proactively, effectively responding to the ever-changing demands of the Region.

This innovative mechanism highlights WBF's commitment to adaptability and responsiveness.

WBF has assembled a remarkable team of experts who supported the Secretariat to design and implement a new grant mechanism that complements and supports the existing grant opportunities offered by the regular WBF Annual Call.

First WBF Move Grants Call for Proposals

The Call was launched in March 2023 first Call for Proposal and received an overwhelming response.

A wide range of applicants, including Civil Society Organizations, non-profit organizations, universities, local public authorities, sports clubs, and individuals from various fields of interest.

The evaluation process for MOVE Grants was conducted internally, leveraging the solid experience of collaborating with CSOs/NGOs and the regional context expertise of the WBF Secretariat.

The process adhered to developed procedures and guidelines aimed at ensuring the quality control of project deliverables and informing future project implementation.

The objective of the evaluation was to assess the relevance, effectiveness, and potential of the grant-awarded projects. MOVE Grants operate as a rolling mechanism, opening three times per year (*March, June, October*)

Move Grants

12 - Info Meetings (in place & online)

57 - Projects Awarded (19 organisations + 38 individuals)

295 - Eligible Projects evaluated

617 - Total applications

210.000 - €, the Move Grant portfolio

+2 million - €, total amount requested (only the first Call)

The data applies to only 1 and 2 Call for Proposals and within the timeline March-August 2023

In order to ensure fairness and equal opportunities, the Western Balkans Fund (WBF) will strive to maintain financial balance among all six Contracting Parties.

The number of projects approved may vary depending on the types of projects and mobilities proposed, as well as the quality of applications received.

2 CfP of the WBF Move Grants

The Second Call for Proposals of the Move Grants was launched on 5 June 2023, with the deadline expiring on 8 June.

For the first time in the history of our Fund, this Call was eligible only to individuals, aiming to participate or develop an exchange & mobility in the Western Balkans Region.

The Second Call for Proposals attracted 193 total applications, with 113 being eligible and passing to the next stage, that of the evaluation process.

After a careful evaluation process, lasting two months, the 34 winners of the 2 CfP were announced on 22 August 2023.



The Info Meeting in Sarajevo

The WBF Move Grants

Winners of the 1st Call for Proposals

Western Balkan Cultural Bridge – Camera Balkanica ArtLink	TAKT Fest 2023 Association Kulturnova	Serbia-North Macedonia MOVE collaboration for the PROteMios discovery of new photodynamic therapy targets for cervical carcinoma Marijana Petkovic
Balkan Love Aleksandar Crnogorac	Study visits and bilateral academic exchange- Faculty of Economics (UDM) and Faculty of Economics (University of Belgrade) Predrag Bjelić	Balkan Short Film Network NGO IACT – OJQ Unš vaproj – NVO Za djelojem
Study visit and bilateral academic exchange Faculty of Economics Maša Baccovic	Football and friendship for gender equality Football club Brestica	Enhancing Regional Cooperation of Young Researchers on Migration & Development GERMIN
Residential Exchange Program for Youth in Kosovo, Serbia, Montenegro, and Bosnia and Herzegovina YIHR	Summer School Transitional Justice, Historian, Teacher and Students Association of History Teachers Kosovo	15th Sarajevo Youth Film Festival Učestvenje Mladih Umjetnika
Research: Engaging Men in Building Gender Equality in Western Balkans (BH, Serbia, Montenegro) - Nikola Vesic	WB6 Diaspora Belonging and Democratic Politics WB6 DIASPOL - Aida Ibrisević	20 International comic showroom "VELES 2023" Comic Center of Macedonia
MEF Energy Forum 2023 ZIP Institute	Study research Marija Krsteva	BEB – Balkan Entrepreneur Bridge the Association for Utilization of Young Entrepreneurs PHOENIX RISING Skopje
Serbia-North Macedonia; PROMETHEAN Katarina Duvaleva	Sustainable Communities Made of Us United Nations Association Albania	Museums Partnership Beyond Borders MuzeLab
Beyond Borders: International Law Training in Belgrade Deel Dervishi	Balkan Film Food Festival of Pogradec Art Im Pulse	

Winners of the 2nd Call for Proposals

Stefana Rosta	Bravo Petkovic	Ljiljana Ristić	Pavle Juretić	Miro Radovanović	Lin Kuo	Mejani Džig
Đura Popović	Petar Stanić	Brin Guranov	Uroš Gvozd	Tijana Trifunović	Marina Stanić	Radina Stanić
Ima Đurđević	Natasha Petrović-Rapovski	Adrian Petrović	Ana Petrović	Grigorijevič Stanić	Alisa Stanić	Olga Stanić
Angelina Žerav	Olga Karamanović-Rapovski	Đorđe Radović	Alisa Stanić	Đorđe Petrović	Natasha Karamanović-Rapovski	Tijana Stanić
Igora Đurđević	Uroš Stanić	Natša Stanić	Grigorijevič Stanić	Đorđe Petrović	Lin Kuo	

The projects of the 1 and 2 CfP of the Move Grants remain under implementation from June 2023, until end of December 2023. The full reporting on those project will be part of the next Annual Report. Scan QR code if you want to learn more about MOVE



MEF 2023 Energy Forum, a project supported by the Move Grants

Balkan Food and Film Festival that took place in Pogradec was partly funded by the Move Grants



Football and friendship for gender equality Cup organised in Pljevlja

Supporting Beyond Grant's Schemes



The Western Balkans Fund has turned it into a habit to use any of its remaining annual budget lines to support the project placed in the reserve list (best of the non-awarded proposals) whenever possible.

Last year, the Fund was able to support six more projects thanks to support by the Swiss SDC and three more are currently implemented thanks to "leftovers" from our EU portfolio.

The projects tackle sexual harassment, social inclusion, marginalization, and contribute to best practices exchange and sustainable development through green tourism.

Supported Projects

1. ApsArt Centre for Theater Research based in Belgrade, with the project "The Hardest Role"
2. Association of Youth with disabilities of Montenegro, with the project "Articulate Inclusion"
3. SpaceSyntaKs, based in Prishtina, with the project "Geotaggers"
4. Center for Energy, Environment and Resources, based in Sarajevo, "Young Western Balkans Ambassadors of Positive Change"
5. Paragliding Sky Riders Prilep, "Birds perspective from Balkan Sky"
6. People in Focus Albania, based in Tirana, "WB Summer School"

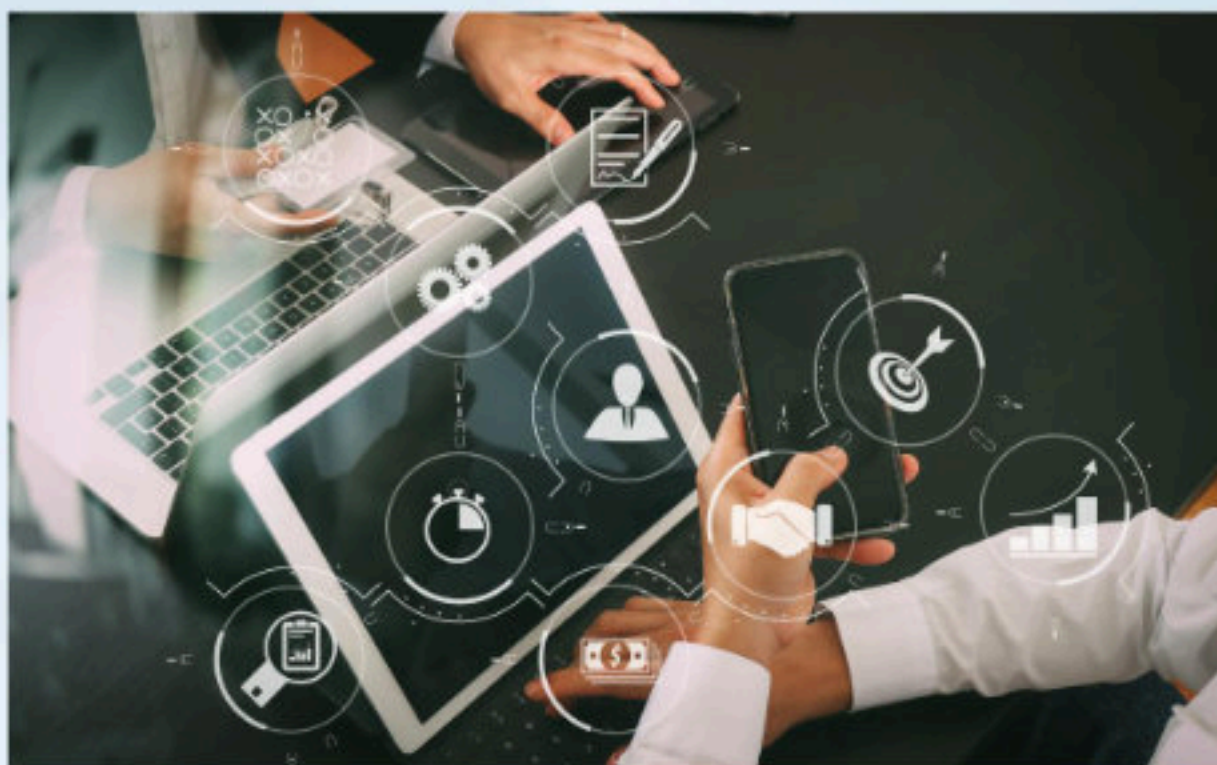


Principle 3

CHAPTER III - Efficiency

- Delivering on key Priorities
- Organisational Development
- Internship Program
- Communication and Visibility

The WBF strives to achieve the best possible results with the minimum resources. The principle of efficiency is therefore applied both in the implementation of projects and administration.



Delivering on key Priorities

WBF implements a robust and adaptable system to effectively assess the outcomes and accomplishments of funded projects.

A comprehensive set of indicators has been developed and systematised, serving as measurable benchmarks for evaluating the success and effectiveness of all grants in promoting sustainable regional cooperation and fostering dynamic people-to-people connections.

These key indicators cover a range of dimensions, including the financial impact and the level of integration of final beneficiaries.

By monitoring these indicators, WBF gains valuable insights into the long-term effects of the grants and can make informed decisions based on the genuine needs of grantees, ultimately contributing to achieving sustainable change in the region.

- High proportion of final beneficiaries are young people with good gender balance
- Significant trend towards decline of repeat beneficiaries meaning that WBF attracted new public in order to increase innovation and collaboration



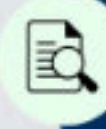
ALL-INCLUSIVE

More than 60% of the applicants are grassroots or newly created organisations. Moreover, 63% of our applicants come from areas outside the capitals. We consider this a relevant achievement that highlights our commitment to supporting grassroots organisations in our region.



FINANCIAL CONTRIBUTION

Financial annual contribution per Contracting parties has been significantly increased since 2017



+205%

Financial annual grant-making envelope has been significantly increased for more than 205% from 2017 to 2023



+233%

Number of supported projects has been significantly increased for 233% in just 6 years



INCREASED DEMAND

All three main thematic areas are having sufficient demand but there is a growing trend of grants and project applications that are covering multisectoral approach (combining more than one thematic area)



- In order to empower (potential) applicants in their attempts to cooperate in the region, WBF built continuous learning culture that enable tailored guidance for all interested to learn how to develop project proposals, how to conduct monitoring and evaluation of project and how to implement project – increase of 100% of (potential) applicants that used mentoring support from 4th to 5th Call for Proposals with 73% of users that assessed mentoring support as responsive to their needs.
- 25% of our grantees reported significant transfer of knowledge within project partner consortia which foster trust and mutual respect through collective decision-making processes.
- Average quality of project proposals has increased between two Call for proposals with decrease of number of project proposals that are not fulfilling technical criteria
- Grantees assess relationship with WBF as positive with 80% of grantees that would apply again and seeing WBF staff as knowledgeable.
- All projects in the 4th Call for proposals were monitored which helped in assessing level of mentorship needed as well as chance to acknowledge and celebrate successes
- Several projects have included and benefitted marginalized groups with encouraging results regarding people-to-people and attitude shifts.

Organisational Development

The Monitoring and Evaluation System system in place plays a vital role in guiding decision-making at all levels of the organization, providing a clear direction for WBF.

It assists in periodizing activities and measuring success, serving as a benchmark for performance and impact assessment.

The system not only evaluates the internal dynamics of the organisation but also assesses its external position. By utilising the MEL system, WBF can make informed decisions, track progress, and ensure that its activities are aligned with its objectives.

This enables WBF to continuously improve and enhance its effectiveness in fostering regional cooperation and achieving its goals.

Key findings

WBF's structure is functional and designed to fulfil its purpose effectively. The organizational structure of WBF enables efficient operations and supports the achievement of its objectives.

WBF demonstrates a commitment to diversifying its funding sources. By actively seeking and securing funding from various donors and partners, WBF reduces dependency on a single source and enhances financial stability.

The overall budget of WBF has increased, reflecting the organization's growth and expanded activities.

This increased budget allows WBF to implement a wider range of programs and initiatives, further advancing its mission and impact.

WBF implements annual financial audits to ensure transparency and accountability.

These audits provide an independent assessment of the organization's financial practices, safeguarding the proper use of funds and maintaining public trust, and follows-up on recommendations

The development of a new organogram for WBF is currently underway, accompanied by the hiring of new staff members who are selected based on merit-based criteria and regional diversity considerations.

This ensures a strong and diverse workforce that can effectively contribute to WBF's goals.

In the past six years, WBF has actively worked towards sustaining and securing partnerships with various donors, aiming to increase financial stability, access new networks, enhance credibility, and expand its impact.



Joint Retreat of the WBF Secretariat with the Members of the Council of Senior Officials

This effort has resulted in the signing of 14 agreements with different partners, donors, and organizations, furthering WBF's collaborative efforts.

WBF implements annual financial audits and adheres to the recommendations provided.

These audits serve as an independent assessment of the organization's financial statements, compliance with regulations, assessment of internal controls, and enhancement of stakeholder confidence.

The audits also help improve financial management practices and ensure the fulfilment of legal and regulatory obligations.

The overall budget of WBF has been increasing since 2017, reflecting the growth and development of the organization.

The grant-making envelope is proportionate to the overall budget, enabling WBF to allocate sufficient resources to its grant programs and effectively support regional initiatives. Full reporting on the financial audit at the Transparency Chapter.

These factors collectively contribute to the continued progress and effectiveness of WBF in promoting regional cooperation and achieving its objectives.

Enhancing the visibility of our mission

Promoting Regional Cooperation is a crucial component of our mission and daily work.

Naturally, we mobilise all our communication channels and influence to advocate for more stakeholder communication and regional cohesion.

In terms of visibility, June 2022-June 23 has been a very important year in which the Western Balkans Fund successfully expanded its regional outreach.

The communication strategy, aligned with the 2020-24 Strategic Development Plan, is based on five components: Public events, Info and Monitoring Sessions, representation visits, social and other media, and publications.

Public Events

In terms of Public Events, since 2022, the Western Balkans Fund has organised several big events, such as:

- FIRE Conference (1-3 March 2022)
- Awarding Ceremony of the 4th Call for Proposals (Mid-April)
- The 3-day workshop and mentoring with the grantees
- The kick-off and the Awarding Ceremony of the Swiss Project
- The Fifth Anniversary of the Western Balkans Fund
- Workshop with the 5th CfP grantees



Dafina Beqiri, Senior Program Manager, representing the Fund at a morning talk show at Top Channel



Uros Citakovic, MEL Officer at WBF giving a statement in Kragujevac



WBF Partnership Platform on Facebook is a unique match-making platform

- The Awarding Ceremony of the 5th Call for Proposals
- The 4-day long Unstoppable Regional Conference

In all the Public Events organised, the ownership of our Contracting Parties and important partnerships have been emphasised.

The public events allowed the Western Balkans Fund to expand its network, reinforce the public image and expand its presence in social & traditional media.

Hundreds of distinguished guests, high-level officials, ambassadors and members of the diplomatic corps, Civil Society prominent leaders, community leaders, entrepreneurs, journalists, and more have participated in our public events.

Info Sessions, Info Days, Mentoring Sessions

The Regional Outreach of the Western Balkans Fund doubled during the reporting period. 18 Info Sessions, spread equally between Contracting Parties of the WB6, occurred between May and July 2023.

Followers of the WBF

823.791

Reach all Socials

597.069

Facebook Reach

109.000

Event Count Web

15.702

Followers FB

13.000

Unique users Web

3.465

Followers Insta

2.542

Followers X

2.265

Followers LinkedIn

2.200

Partnership Platform

290

Threads

Note: Data collected on 15.08.2023
Representing the period from 1
June 2022 to the date of Collection

Moreover, for the first time, the Western Balkans Fund piloted Info Days, a new format in which team members tour a different country to engage in the field and meet potential grantees.

The Info Sessions and Info Days allowed the Western Balkans Fund to engage directly with 1.000 individuals or Civil Society Organisations in their respective home locations.

To add up, for the first time, since 2022, the Secretariat organises regularly Online Mentoring Sessions in all the official languages of the Region (Albanian, Bosnian, Croatian, Macedonian, Montenegrin and Serbian), plus English. In the Mentoring Session, delivered through the Zoom platform, close to 500 more stakeholders participated.

Partnership Platform

Additionally to our communication channels, we pioneer a Partnership Platform with currently 2.200 members in Facebook. The platform is a matching tool between organisations that look for new regional partners.



Camera and Media Representatives at a WBF-organised ceremony

Representational visits

Representation visits are events organised by other stakeholders but where we have been invited to participate actively.

During 2022, the Secretariat was invited and attended important conferences or summits, such as UN-Habitat Forum in Katowice, Berlin Process in Berlin, the EU organised, TACSO, EUSAIR and other important events.

In 2023, we have participated, among others in the Budapest Balkans Forum, Globsec Forum, Prespa Dialogue Forum, etc.

The Western Balkans Fund team also attended events organised by our partners in Albania and abroad and events organised by the partners' Embassies. Overall, the Western Balkans Fund achieved close to 50 representative visits in the monitoring period.

Social Media and webpage

The reporting period has been astonishing in terms of the growth of our social media communication channels and the webpage.

13 thousand single visitors have received direct information from our homepage, generating traffic of 108 thousand actions (such as reading a new article, visiting gallery, downloading, etc.) in the webpage.

In regard to the social media, during the reported timeline, we added our presence to LinkedIn and Threads, while also increasing our reliance on Youtube Channel thanks to more audiovisual content generated by the Fund and by our partners.



From 1 June 2022, our content on Facebook, in total 351 posts, has reached 597 thousand accounts.

Only ¼ of the reach is paid, with the rest being organic. Compared with the previous period of time (the previous 13 months), the growth of reach is 47%. Instagram, another social media widely used by the Fund, a reach is over 50 thousand.

Moreover, significant increases have been noticed on Twitter, LinkedIn and Youtube. All combined, the Western Balkans Fund has over 30 thousand loyal followers in social media.

General Media

Public Events, selected projects and success stories have been featured in the general media, including news portals, blogs, television, magazine and radio.

For the first time, the Fund has published content also in selected channels controlled by the European Union. Our team has been present in different tv and radio talk shows in all the Contracting Parties. Among the most influential medias that have reported on our Fund and stories is Radio Free Europe, N1 Network, Top Channel, We Balkans portal, etc.



Do you know that

- **We have a unique collection of monthly Newsletters representing the 5 last years of the WBF.**
- **We have a unique collection of galleries, featuring more than 200 important events that WBF organised or participated since establishment**
- **We have a special focus on reporting success stories and all the achievements of our grantees.**

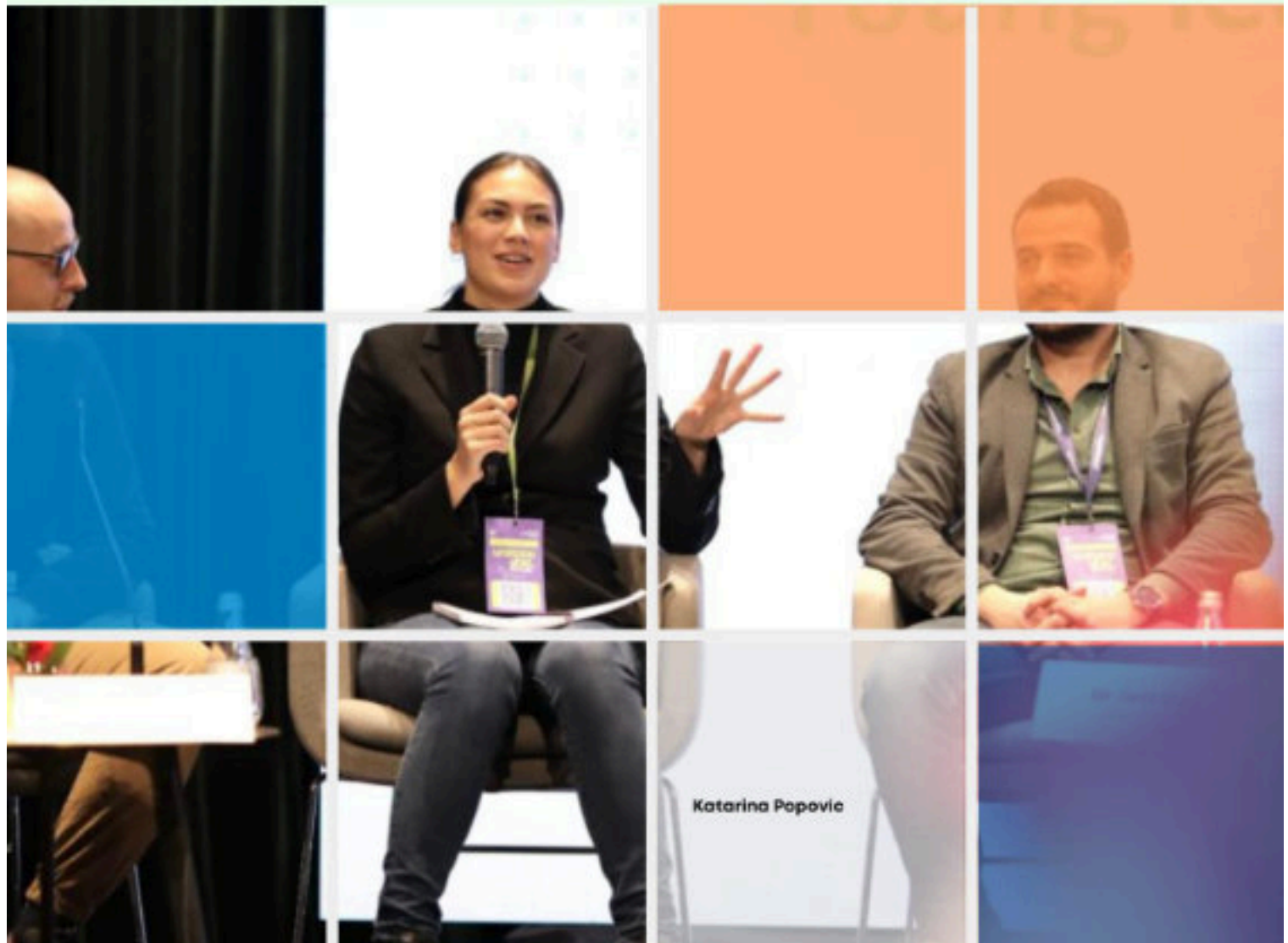
For all of this and more, visit our webpage - www.westernbalkansfund.org

5 years of monthly Newsletter



Creating shared value through our internship programme

The WBF Internship Program provides a valuable opportunity for youth empowerment in the Western Balkans. Supported by the International Visegrad Fund, the program offers a three-week internship at the WBF Secretariat, focusing on grant management and public relations. Participants gain professional development and regional networking, fostering mutual experiences, values, traditions, and culture. This program promotes good neighbourly relations and enhances knowledge about regional cooperation and the specific objectives of the WBF.



WBF hosted 4 interns from the WB6 region at its Secretariat between December 2022 and July 2023.

The interns, Brandon Muhedini from Tirana, Katarina Popovic from Belgrade, Katarina Konatar from Podgorica, and Rita Zhubi from Pristina, were selected through an open call process.

They demonstrated strong motivation to work in the field of regional cooperation and had diverse academic backgrounds with international experience. It is worth noting that since its establishment, WBF has provided internship opportunities to a total of 10 individuals at its Secretariat.

During their time at the WBF Secretariat, the interns had the valuable opportunity to enhance their understanding and knowledge in various cross-cutting areas.

These included, but were not limited to, reconciliation, promoting good neighborly relations, advancing gender equality, empowering youth, fostering cross-border cooperation, and supporting European integration efforts.

Through their engagement with WBF projects and activities, the interns gained practical insights and hands-on experience in these important fields of regional cooperation.

The development curriculum focused on key skills and qualities essential for success, including collaboration, leadership, integrative thinking, and innovation.

Through a combination of hands-on experiences, interactive workshops, mentorship, and learning resources, interns were encouraged to cultivate these skills and foster a culture of continuous learning.



Brandon Muhedini



Rita Zhubi



Katarina Konatar

CHAPTER IV - Effectiveness

- Strategic Development
- Monitoring and Evaluation

Principle 4

The WBF attaches great importance to achieving a clear and concrete results and has developed mechanisms to monitor its work and the results of its projects. As such, this strategic plan represents the basis of cooperation between the Western Balkans Fund and civil society around the Western Balkans Region, by committing the financial support of six governments in creating favourable conditions for strengthening regional cooperation.





Strategic Development

WBF implements a robust and adaptable system to effectively assess the outcomes and accomplishments of funded projects.

A comprehensive set of indicators has been developed and systematized, serving as measurable benchmarks for evaluating the success and effectiveness of all grants in promoting sustainable regional cooperation and fostering dynamic people-to-people connections.

These key indicators cover a range of dimensions, including the financial impact and the level of integration of final beneficiaries.

By monitoring these indicators, WBF gains valuable insights into the long-term effects of the grants and can make informed decisions based on the genuine needs of grantees, ultimately contributing to achieving sustainable change in the region.

High proportion of final beneficiaries are young people with good gender balance

Significant trend towards decline of repeat beneficiaries meaning that WBF attracted new public in order to increase innovation and collaboration



Illustrative picture: Both RK Borac Banja Luka and Crvena Zvezda are grantees of the 5th Call for Proposals

Using MEL, allowed WBF gained insights into partnership quality, the scope of work of civil society organizations, their needs, and the regional context on key topics.

These learnings prompted WBF to make program adjustments that reflect the genuine needs of stakeholders.

To enhance awareness, communication, and outreach efforts, WBF has recognized the importance of Info sessions as a key tool for direct engagement with grantees.

Over the past year, WBF has witnessed a notable increase in attendance at these events, resulting in improved engagement with applicants and grantees.

By providing opportunities for newcomers, WBF is fostering a more diverse and dynamic regional cooperation landscape.

An impressive 70% of grantees have reported that their WBF projects have significantly enhanced their ability to engage beneficiaries in regional cooperation initiatives.

This statistic highlights the positive impact of WBF projects in strengthening the involvement and participation of individuals and communities in regional cooperation efforts.

It demonstrates the effectiveness of WBF's support in empowering grantees to effectively engage and mobilize beneficiaries for impactful regional cooperation projects.

“

The successful implementation of the Calls for Proposals is the best example of the European value of this regional instrument (WBF), which involves a large number of representatives from the NGO sector, education and local self-governments in joint project activities with their neighbors

H.E. Nikola Dimitrov, former Minister of Foreign Affairs of the North Macedonia

Furthermore, these sessions have positively impacted the dissemination of information, effectively reaching a wider audience and fostering greater understanding of WBF's initiatives.

The number of lead applicants who are newcomers to regional cooperation and have reported little to no experience in managing and implementing regional projects has increased compared to previous calls.

This signifies a positive trend towards greater inclusivity and the engagement of fresh perspectives in regional initiatives.

There is a high level of reported satisfaction regarding cooperation among partners, with a notable emphasis on the effective transfer of knowledge.

This highlights the success of collaboration between various stakeholders in sharing valuable insights and expertise.

The strong level of satisfaction demonstrates the positive impact of cooperative efforts in fostering knowledge exchange, ultimately contributing to the achievement of project goals and objectives.



EU staff family picture at the 5th Anniversary Reception, October 2022

Strong results have been achieved in terms of motivation for regional cooperation and the creation of regional networks.

These outcomes demonstrate the positive impact of WBF initiatives in fostering a sense of motivation and enthusiasm among participants to actively engage in regional cooperation efforts.

The establishment of regional networks further enhances collaboration and creates a platform for ongoing exchange, facilitating the achievement of common goals and objectives.

WBF support for projects has led to a high level of reported strengthening of the ability to forge partnerships across borders.

Grantees have acknowledged the positive impact of WBF initiatives in facilitating cross-border collaborations and enhancing their capacity to establish meaningful partnerships.

This demonstrates the effectiveness of WBF's project support in fostering regional cooperation and promoting sustained engagement among diverse stakeholders across borders.

In order to promote skills development, facilitate knowledge transfer, and foster learning exchanges, WBF introduced a program of internships, resulting in the branding of 9 Ambassadors of regional cooperation and reconciliation.

Remarkably, half of these ambassadors reported that the experience helped them gain a deeper understanding of the region. Additionally, for the majority of them, this was their first professional encounter within a multicultural environment.

Over the past six years, WBF has been actively focused on sustaining and securing partnerships with various donors.

The objective is to not only enhance financial stability but also to access new networks, bolster credibility, and broaden impact.

During this time, WBF has successfully signed 14 agreements with a range of partners, donors, and organizations.

These partnerships signify WBF's commitment to expanding its reach, diversifying support, and strengthening collaborations to achieve its mission and goal.

Monitoring & Mentoring



WBF-EU Project Manager, Mr. Bisha, at the WBF Partnership Workshop with the grantees of the 5th Call for Proposal

Do you know that?

WBF is one of the unique donors that cares to create a strong partnership model with the grantees. Since 2022, the WBF has been able to monitor and provide direct support to all 66 projects implemented in the framework of 4th and 5th Call for Proposals

The monitoring and mentoring process is an important integral part of the WBF grant scheme that is mostly dedicated to the support for successful implementation of projects implemented by third parties.

The monitoring process is a complex one, however the WBF assigns one Program Manager per Contracting Party who becomes the focal point for mentoring support and communication with selected grantees.

Six Program Managers ensures ongoing support and guidance, that also conducted at least one in-person for monitoring purpose and provide any necessary assistance.

This direct engagement allows the Fund to develop a comprehensive understanding about the projects and facilitate effective monitoring.

Furthermore, with the direct support of the Monitoring, Evaluation and Learning Officer the WBF offered additional support during the reporting process, where grantees received comprehensive guidance and assistance until the completion of their projects, guaranteeing smooth project closure and accurate reporting.

The 4th Call for Proposals became the first in which WBF managers monitored physically at the 30 projects during the implementation phase.



CHAPTER V - Transparency

- Responsible management of the finances
- Digitalisation and Innovation

Principle 5

Principle Number 5: Transparency Information about activities and overall management has always been publicly available because the WBF believes that openness and accountability is very important.



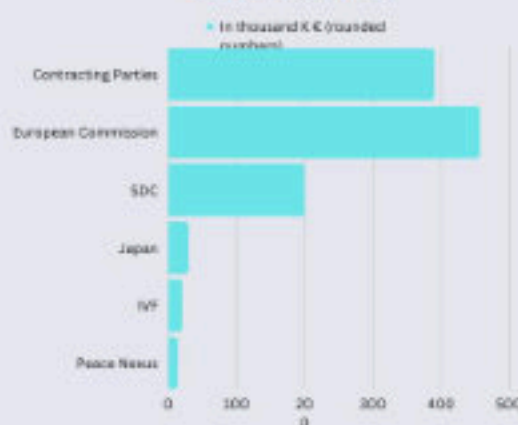
Responsible finance management

During the period of March 2023 to May 2023, WBF conducted the audit of financial statements for the year 2022. This important process was performed by the independent auditor UHY Elite.

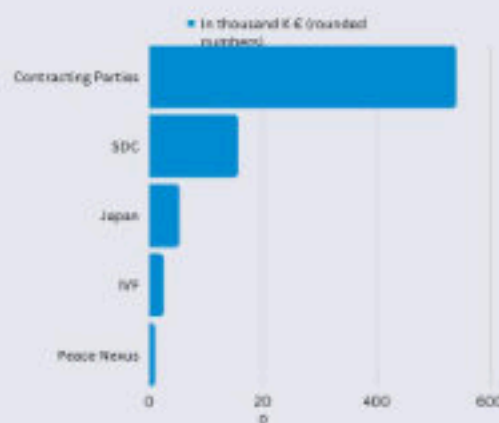
UHY Elite is one of the top 20 biggest accounting firms in Albania and is a full member of UHY International which is among 20 firms of the world's leading business advisory, consulting and accounting networks, with teams operating across nearly 300 offices in 100 countries worldwide.

WBF emphasizes the importance of this process which provides assurance for the shareholders that the financial statements are presented accurately and aligned with all the regulations and standards applicable.

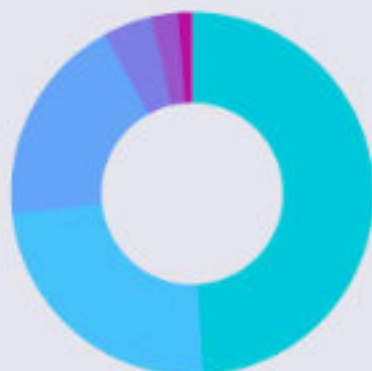
2022 Budget



2023 Budget



2022-23 Budget | The origin of the Funds



- 49.1% | The Contracting Parties of the WBF
- 24.1% | The European Commission
- 18.8% | Swiss Agency for Cooperation and Development
- 4.4% | Ministry of Foreign Affairs of Japan
- 2.4% | The International Visegrad Fund
- 1.2% | Peace Nexus Foundation

INDEPENDENT AUDITOR'S REPORT

To the Executive Director and Conference of Ministers of Foreign Affairs of Western Balkan Fund

Opinion

We have audited the statement of financial position of Western Balkans Fund ("The Organization") which comprise the financial position on 31 December 2022, the statement of activities and the statement of cash flows for the year then ended and notes to the financial statements, including a summary of significant accounting policies.

In our opinion, the accompanying financial statements of Western Balkan Fund on 31 December 2022, are prepared in all material respects in accordance with the Modified cash basis of accounting as described in Note 2.

Tirana
Date 17 May 2023





Innovation & Digitalisation

For the first three Calls for Proposals, the applicant had to email or mail their applications by post.

After collecting all applications with the evaluations manually, the Secretariat proceeded to select the best 18 or 24 projects out of hundreds of applications.

This approach was time-consuming for our applicants and the Secretariat staff.

We began a big innovation undertaking to address this issue, fully digitalizing the application system.

In line with this progress, the WBF Applicant Portal was introduced during the 4th Call, serving as the primary tool for applying to WBF Calls.

The digitalization of grant applications has had a transformative impact, revolutionizing the process to enhance efficiency, accessibility, and transparency.

In collaboration with the GoEasy Team, the Western Balkans Fund (WBF) has developed the WBF Grantee Portal, a new platform dedicated to monitoring the progress of activities and facilitating the financial and narrative reporting process for projects funded through the WBF 5th Call.

Do you know

The OGMS (Online Grant Management System) provides the applicants with a 24/7 gateway reaching straight at the core of WBF.

It takes less than a minute to complete a registration and less than 1 hour to complete an application.

Furthermore, the OGMS is not just an application portal, but it has been designed to be an interactive tool, providing applicants with information, tutorials and "how to do it" videos that combined increase access and transparency of our organisation



Print screen of the Applicant Portal

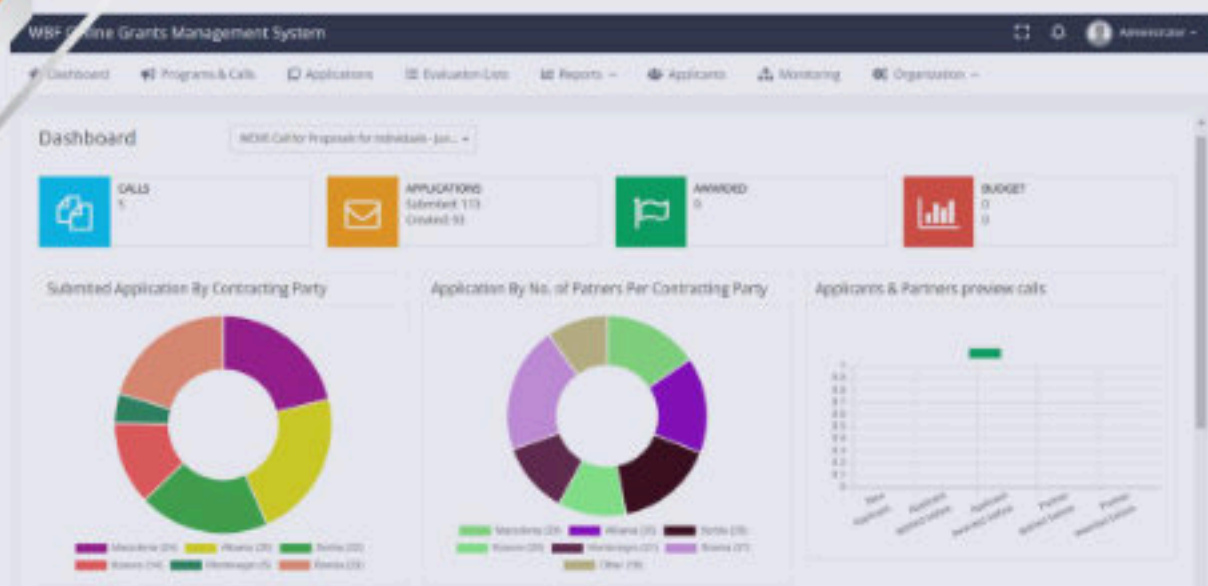
This shift to digital platforms has empowered a more comprehensive range of applicants, simplified operations, and fostered collaboration.

By embracing these digital tools, grant-makers and applicants alike have benefited from a more effective and inclusive grant ecosystem.

This advancement has led to a reduction in paperwork, improved accessibility, and a user-friendly system. Furthermore, it is now much easier to stay updated on the status of applications after submission.

Building on this success, WBF, in collaboration with the GoEasy Team, has developed the WBF Grantee Portal.

This new digital mechanism enables the collection of relevant data on project implementation, facilitates progress monitoring of activities, and streamlines financial and narrative reporting for the projects funded through the WBF 5th Call. The WBF Grantee Portal represents a significant step forward in optimizing the grantee experience and ensuring effective project management.



Interface of the Online Grant Management System

Benefits of the OGMS

The push towards modernisation has brought tangible benefits to the Fund. Thanks to the Development of the OGMS:

The number of ineligible applications has dropped immediately with the implementation of the system. In the last two Calls for Proposals, the number fell to 3% and 2% respectively. The average rate of ineligible applications before the implementation of this system was 11%, with the highest being 14% of the total number of applicants.

The Fund is able to follow the trends live and online. This enables us to take real-time decisions that enhances our regional outreach, making possible to focus on areas that have not been sufficiently represented. Through this approach, we are able to provide a better distribution of our grants.

The system is interactive, rich with many features that allow the potential applicants to get real-time information about how to apply or what steps to follow next.

It has increased the transparency of the application system. The elimination of the human-element in the application stage has made possible a totally equal treatment for all the applicants.

The system stores information that before went straight to the archive and was available only by request. The information stored is available to all stakeholders.

Finally, thanks to the modernising efforts we have become a better organisation, much more transparent, open and forward thinking.

The way forward

**Future expansion,
cooperation with
partners, further
grant portfolio
diversification.**

**Discover what is in
our plate in the
near future**

Western Balkans Fund has made significant progress in the past 6 years focusing on becoming a reliable partner in the region, an organisation which endorses lessons learnt and strengthens its capacities while envisioning a sustainable growth.

While looking at the previous years, we take stock of the great results WBF has cultivated, while diligently preserving our unique nature as a regional grant giving organisation with sound foundations and management assets that can allow us to take a meaningful leapfrog.

WBF is ready to grow and put to good use the knowledge and experience we have built up. It is time for us to become even more present in the region, intensify our efforts to support a wider range of actors throughout the Western Balkans.

The demand for regional partnership, cooperation and exchange between the six Contracting Parties of the Western Balkans is present more than ever. We are the witnesses of many positive synergies that need to be replicated, encouraged, supported and celebrated.

Western Balkans Fund, led by innovative and accountable practices is ready to boost its impact in the region and share its immeasurable knowledge and support to the vibrant regional demand for cooperation that is thriving everyday more.



Sneak-peek to what comes next

During the following period, inspired by this flourishing regional climate, Western Balkans Fund aims to increase support through different types of grants for organisations and individuals in the region.

Our Strategic and Organizational Development Plan has guided the strengthening of the structure and management of our organisation in these past years. In the following period Western Balkans Fund will start compiling its next Strategy, shaping the future of its developments, support and partnerships.

Our Monitoring Evaluation and Learning instruments continue to inspire us every day by furnishing us with data and messages from our region and enabling us to define long-term goals and identify necessary preconditions.

Our partners are our biggest asset. The following months will be the time of strengthened and consolidated partnerships and extension of our network of donors and partners who share the same vision.

Regional is Good. Regional is better! And we believe in cooperation as the denominator of the common prosperous regional future.

OUR TEAM



EXECUTIVE
DIRECTOR

Gjergj Murra



SENIOR PROGRAM
MANAGER

Dafina Beqiri

“

All of us are giving our best to the success of the WBF, its mission and objectives. But, also WBF is giving to all of us a unique opportunity to grow, enrich our lives and to perform what we really trust: A better region and common European Future



PROGRAM
MANAGER

Ksenija Vukmirović



JOINT ACTION
PROJECT MANAGER

Fjordi Bisha



PROJECT
COORDINATOR

Valbona Dedja



FINANCE ADMINISTRATION
MANAGER

Ilir Umeri



DIVERSIFIED GRANT
PORTFOLIO COORDINATOR

Erinda Toska



DIVERSIFIED GRANT
PORTFOLIO ASSISTANT

Hanan Kovačević



MEL
OFFICER

Uroš Čitaković



PUBLIC RELATIONS
OFFICER

Klevis Gjoni



GRANT
COORDINATOR

Enea Korkuti



HUMAN
RESOURCES

Anela Valjevac



FINANCE AND
ADMINISTRATION OFFICER

Juliana Muço



ACCOUNTANT

Orgeta Buna

Funny Facts about our team

14

Employees



Secretariat, located
in Tirana

6

Number of
nationalities
working in the
Secretariat

20

Languages spoken by our staff:
English, French, Italian, Spanish,
Portuguese, German, Russian,
Polish, Hebrew, Turkish, Chinese,
Norwegian, Latin, Albanian,
Bosnian, Croatian, Macedonian,
Serbian

Past Publications

18

Studies in: United
States, Italy, Israel,
Turkey, China, Austria,
Netherlands, Poland,
Germany, Slovenia,
Croatia, Hungary,
Albania, Bosnia and
Herzegovina, Kosovo,
Montenegro, North
Macedonia, Serbia



 **Rruga Skenderbej, No. 8, Kati IV, Ap 35/36, Tirane, Albania**

 **info@westernbalkansfund.org**

 **www.westernbalkansfund.org**

 **+355 42 400 420**

